

(Non-)Ideological Oversight of the Executive Branch: Evidence from Congress and Offices of Inspector General*

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Abstract

Congress delegates significant policy-making and administrative powers to federal agencies. Congress conducts oversight to solve the principal-agent problem that this delegation creates, but scholars are divided on when Congress prioritizes ideology and partisan concerns over policy quality/valence concerns when conducting oversight. This paper contributes to this debate by analyzing Offices of Inspector General (OIG). I posit that Congress is incentivized to manipulate the capacity and oversight agendas of these offices in order to achieve their political goals, in spite of the ostensibly non-ideological oversight that OIGs conduct. Using data on OIG budgets, non-statutory directives in appropriations reports, witnesses in committee hearings and congressional e-newsletters, I find suggestive evidence that Congress prioritizes policy valence concerns when directing the oversight agenda of OIGs while also inviting OIGs to testify more often when it is convenient for their political goals. This hints at a complementarity between ideological oversight and non-ideological oversight, where politically-minded usage of information gathered in oversight is predicated on the non-partisan credibility of the information being shared.

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Introduction

One fundamental problem driving the existence and growth of the federal bureaucracy in the United States is that Congress does not have the time or capacity to write all of the laws for the country on its own. Congress therefore delegates significant policymaking and policy implementation powers to federal agencies, anticipating that the expertise and capacity of agency bureaucrats will produce more effective policies. This delegation brings with it the principal-agent problem of ensuring that the policies produced by federal agencies do not stray too far from Congress’s policy preferences, including ideological preferences and preferences over policy valence, otherwise known as quality.¹ Congress has utilized both ex-ante (statutory limitations on policy-making, appropriations riders, etc) and ex-post (committee hearings, mandatory reporting requirements) tools to solve this agency problem, but the relative success of these measures remains a hot topic of scholarly and popular debate.

Much of the literature on congressional oversight of the executive branch focuses on the question of whether ideology/partisanship or policy valence concerns predict oversight frequency/intensity and under what conditions members of Congress pursue one form of oversight over the other. Findings have been mixed, with some citing the predictive power of divided government and/or policy alignment on oversight (Kriner and Schwartz 2008, McGrath 2013, Parker and Dull 2013, Bolton 2022) and others citing policy valence concerns as important drivers of oversight, particularly in private communications with agencies (Lowande 2018). However, the literature’s focus on examining one mechanism of oversight at a time has left questions unanswered about how these mechanisms relate to one another, raising the possibility that ideological and non-ideological oversight in different venues may be complementary to one another and further Congress’s policy and electoral goals.

¹In this paper, I use the term ‘valence’ to refer to the quality of the implementation of a given policy, rather than the salience of a policy among the electorate. For example, a federal construction project that wastes money hiring expensive contractors with little experience would have lower valence than if said construction project were implemented with a cost-effective contractor instead. All actors are assumed to prefer a higher valence policy over a lower valence policy, holding ideological location constant (Hirsch and Shotts 2012).

This paper contributes to this ongoing debate by examining congressional control of Offices of Inspector General (OIG), an understudied yet highly consequential set of institutions in the U.S. federal government. OIGs are non-partisan, politically independent offices in executive branch agencies that conduct audits and investigations of the agency that they are housed in, issuing reports and recommendations aimed at minimizing waste and fraud in federal agency operations. Although they are housed in the executive branch, OIGs are unique in that they have a dual reporting role to both the head of their agency and Congress and also substantial statutory independence from their parent agencies, such as through their separate appropriations accounts and the requirement of advance congressional notification before their removal.

OIGs are useful for examining this debate, as the oversight they conduct is very much focused on correcting policy valence instead of ideological ‘drift’. Therefore, if ideological/partisan motivations explain patterns of congressional interactions with OIGs, it provides strong evidence of ideological/partisan incentives’ ability to explain patterns of congressional oversight as a whole. OIGs also contribute to Congress’s oversight efforts in a variety of ways, allowing for the study of multiple oversight mechanisms and further theorizing about how they complement each other.

In this paper, I present a theory of how members of Congress are incentivized by political incentives to manipulate OIGs’ auditing agenda and capacity in accordance with the broader political environment. I leverage OIG budget authority data, non-statutory directives to both OIGs and their parent agencies in appropriations committee reports, witness invitation data and congressional e-newsletters to test this theory and assess if members of Congress prioritize partisanship/ideological disagreements over policy valence or other considerations in their oversight of the executive branch.

The mixed predictive power of political incentives on oversight intensity in these different empirical tests is suggestive of a complementarity between political and valence motivations for congressional oversight. OIG budgets and directives are not subject to consistent and significant political influence, be it through presidential opposition or ideological divergence, however, OIG witness patterns and mentions of Inspectors General in

e-newsletters are congruent with political motivations for oversight. I posit that members of Congress have an incentive to refrain from politicizing the oversight that OIGs conduct because the value of their oversight to Congress comes from their reputation in the public eye as trustworthy non-ideological watchdogs. If Congress were to manipulate OIG oversight capacity or their agendas, it would, in effect, ‘poison the well’ and endanger the bipartisan credibility that makes OIG oversight so valuable for Congress.

By questioning the strict distinction between ideological and non-ideological oversight and examining an underexplored institution that conducts significant oversight of the executive branch, this paper highlights the importance of conceptualizing oversight as more than just a set of actions conducted in isolation by members of Congress. Different oversight mechanisms serve different goals of members of Congress and it is necessary to incorporate multiple oversight mechanisms and actors to have a complete understanding of congressional oversight and the incentives that drive the behavior of members of Congress with regards to holding the executive branch accountable.

Congressional Oversight

The elected representatives of Congress and their body of staffers are responsible for writing the laws of the federal government. However, Congress, as an institution, does not have the capacity or expertise to write all laws for a country of over 300 million people with an annual GDP of over 25 trillion USD. This has led to significant delegation of policy-making powers to the executive branch, including the President and federal agencies. Many federal regulations are written by federal agencies through the federal rulemaking process, with these statutes having the same legal standing as those written by Congress.² With delegation, Congress runs the risk of federal agencies drifting from Congress’s preferences, whether it be preferences over the ideological location of policy or preferences over the efficiency/quality of implementation of policy, i.e. policy valence.

²The modern federal rulemaking process was standardized with the Administrative Procedure Act of 1946. Worth noting here is that there are even more instances of informal rulemaking by federal agencies that, although not having the same legal authority as federal statutes, still shape behavior and compliance amongst regulated parties (Parrillo 2019, Potter 2020).

To control bureaucratic inefficiency, shirking, and policy drift, Congress turns to oversight, which is defined by McCubbins and Schwartz as actions taken by Congress to “detect and remedy executive-branch violations of legislative goals” (1984). These legislative goals, drawing from canonical conceptualizations of the goals of members of Congress (Fenno 1973, Mayhew 2004), can include both the implementation of policy congruent with a member’s ideological preferences and efficient implementation of policy more generally. Congress has a number of oversight ‘tools’ at their disposal—some of these oversight mechanisms are ‘formal’ in that they require significant coordination between multiple members of Congress, such as the design of statutes (Huber and Shipan 2002), committee hearings (Aberbach 1990, Mayhew 1991, Kriner and Schwartz 2008, McGrath 2013, Parker and Dull 2013) and limitation riders (Macdonald 2010), but others are more informal and require the involvement of as little as one member of Congress, such as private communications with federal agencies (Lowande 2018, Ritchie 2018, Lowande, Ritchie, and Lauterbach 2019, Ritchie and You 2019, Ritchie 2023), comments on federal rules (Lowande and Potter 2021), non-statutory directives in appropriations reports (Bolton 2022), and directing actors outside of Congress to conduct oversight of the executive branch (Kempf and Cabrera 2019, Drolc 2020). The use of oversight tools may be, in part, dictated by congressional capacity and legislative gridlock, as more formal methods of oversight may be unfeasible when ideological divisions within, and between, chambers of Congress and the President paralyze the lawmaking process and capacity constraints force members of Congress to pursue less costly and more informal means of overseeing the executive branch (McGrath 2013, Bolton 2022).

A salient question in the congressional oversight literature is when and where ideological disagreements or policy valence concerns predict oversight frequency and intensity by Congress. Scholars have found different answers depending on the type of oversight being conducted, with private and informal oversight, such as private communications with federal agency, hewing more towards non-ideological concerns such as constituent service and policy efficiency (Lowande 2018, though see Ritchie 2018) and public-facing oversight, particularly committee hearings, focusing on ideological and partisan concerns

(Kriner and Schwartz 2008, McGrath 2013). A common thread connecting these findings is that the incentives for members of Congress to ‘pander’ to their electorates by focusing on ideological oversight are most salient in public-facing oversight, leaving private oversight as the pathway to oversee issues with fewer electoral benefits.

The lumping together of actions as disparate as committee hearings, private communications with agencies, and statute design under the umbrella of oversight, alongside the very different incentives surrounding each, illustrates the need for more theoretical clarity about oversight. The various mechanisms of congressional oversight do not exist in a vacuum and, in fact, likely feed into each other: congressional hearings often cite information gathered by congressional staffers through private communications with agencies, private communications between members of Congress and agencies can be sparked by the findings of an audit conducted by the Government Accountability Office, and audits themselves can be requested by Congress either in private communications or in statute. However, most empirical studies of congressional oversight only look at one of these oversight mechanisms at a time, leaving room for scholarship that bridges the theoretical gaps between these different oversight mechanisms that exhibit radically different patterns of ideological influence.

Building on this, Selin and Moore posit that congressional oversight is “a series of actions designed both to gather information on the executive and to facilitate legislative credit claiming and position taking” (Selin and Moore 2023, 187). Selin and Moore’s conceptualization highlights the distinction between the information gathering and political signaling aspects of oversight, with information gathering typically coming before political signaling in the oversight ‘process’. Though most oversight mechanisms can be construed as pursuing both information provision and political signaling (Eldes, Fong, and Lowande 2024), some are certainly more ripe for political signaling than others, particularly committee hearings, and it appears that the suitability of oversight mechanisms for political signaling is what drives the empirical patterns seen in the literature.

Importantly, conceptualizing congressional oversight as a ‘series of actions’ raises the possibility of a complementarity between ideological and non-ideological oversight. By

only looking at one form of oversight at a time, the literature has yet to fully consider how Congress’s ideological and non-ideological motivations for oversight may not only be satisfied at different steps in the oversight ‘process’ but may also be complemented by one another, with a focus on non-ideological issues in one realm of oversight potentially contributing to the pursuit of ideological goals in other forms of oversight.

This paper contributes to this gap in the literature by examining congressional control of Offices of Inspector General (OIGs). These offices, housed in the executive branch but with statutory protections from presidential influence, conduct vital oversight of executive branch agencies with a focus on oversight of non-ideological issues, such as efficiency of government programs and criminal abuses within the executive branch. Together with the Government Accountability Office (GAO), these offices comprise the majority of the governmental workforce employed in executive branch oversight³ and contribute most directly to the information provision aspect of congressional oversight.

This paper expands upon the existing debate over the influence of ideology on congressional oversight in a few ways—first, by examining an underexplored oversight institution that primarily focuses on oversight of non-ideological issues and is prized for their independent, non-political expertise, the paper provides something of a ‘conservative’ test for the influence of ideology on congressional oversight more broadly. Second, by examining the various stages in the oversight ‘process’ in which Congress can utilize and manipulate the oversight conducted by OIGs for information gathering and political signaling, this paper hints at a complementarity between non-ideological information gathering and political signaling, as the non-partisan and expert reputation of OIGs is what allows Congress to effectively capitalize on their oversight for political signaling purposes. In the next section, I discuss OIGs in more detail, establish the non-ideological nature of the work they conduct, and outline the various ways in which Congress can manipulate the oversight conducted by OIGs for their ideological oversight goals.

³As of 2024, roughly 14000 people are employed at the various OIGs in the federal government, and the GAO employed 3510 people in 2023. In comparison, the House and Senate employed 15147 staffers in 2022, with only 2372 of them working in committees where oversight duties are most likely to occur (Petersen 2023, Petersen 2023, Temin 2024). The employment numbers likely underestimate the amount of oversight being conducted in OIGs and the GAO versus Congress, as congressional staffers are employed for a variety of duties whereas the other two institutions are primarily focused on oversight.

Congress and Offices of Inspector General

Members of Congress are not alone in conducting oversight of the executive branch, particularly when it comes to gathering information on the executive branch. They are supported by congressional staffers who gather information in preparation for committee hearings, congressional support organizations such as the Government Accountability Office (GAO) and the Congressional Research Service (CRS), as well as the topic of this paper—Offices of Inspector General (OIG). OIGs are an important set of institutions whose main role is to conduct oversight of the executive branch, specifically with an eye towards reducing waste and fraud in government spending. Unlike the aforementioned congressional support organizations, OIGs are housed in the executive branch, giving them more ‘on-the-ground’ expertise of federal agency operations and a unique dual-reporting role to both Congress and the head of their agency. These institutions have their roots in the 1970’s and 1980’s, with many cabinet-level OIGs being formed after the passage of the Inspector General Act of 1978 (IG Act), which laid the framework for the modern OIG institution (Wilhelm 2023). OIGs are headed by an Inspector General (IG), a non-partisan, ostensibly politically independent official that is either nominated by the President and confirmed by the Senate, or directly appointed by the head of the agency under the OIG’s jurisdiction.⁴

According to a Congressional Research Service report, the IG Act specifies three main purposes for Inspectors General—

1. “Conduct audits and investigations of programs and operations of their affiliated federal entities;⁵
2. “Recommend policies that promote the efficiency, economy, and effectiveness of

⁴These two methods of appointment are commonly referred to as PAS (Presidential Appointment and Senate Confirmation) and DFE (stands for Designated Federal Entity, refers to IGs that are appointed directly by agency heads). Most high-profile federal agencies, including all cabinet-level agencies and most large independent agencies, have PAS IGs.

⁵‘Affiliated Federal Entities’ are departments or offices under the scope of a given OIG. Most OIGs cover one specific federal agency, but a few cover more than one agency, such as the EPA OIG’s jurisdiction including the Chemical Safety Board, and a few agencies have more than one OIG, such as the Department of Treasury with the Treasury OIG and the Treasury Inspector General for Tax Administration that covers the IRS.

agency programs and operations, as well as preventing and detecting waste, fraud, and abuse;

3. “Keep the affiliated entity head and Congress “fully and currently informed” of fraud and “other serious problems, abuses, and deficiencies” in such programs and operations, as well as progress in implementing related corrective actions.” (Wilhelm 2023)

The work of OIGs is commonly split into two categories—audits, inspections and evaluations, which analyze the efficiency and efficacy of government programs, and investigations, which examine allegations of fraud, misconduct, and corrupt actions by agency employees and contractors. The former category is where OIGs produce policy recommendations for agency operations. These recommendations are largely geared towards improving the efficiency of agency operations and programs and not towards pushing a specific ideological vision of what the agency should be doing. On top of these, OIGs conduct peer reviews of other OIGs and publish semiannual reports for Congress detailing their activities in a 6 month reporting period, including a list of open recommendations that agencies have yet to implement. Table 1 provides a sampling of reports produced by various OIGs.

Table 1: Examples of OIG Reports

Type of Report	Title	Agency	Date
Audit	FINANCIAL MANAGEMENT: Audit of the Federal Financing Bank’s Financial Statements for Fiscal Years 2024 and 2023	Department of Treasury	11/12/24
Inspection / Evaluation	Inspection of the Federal Bureau of Prisons’ Federal Medical Center Devens	Department of Justice	12/11/24
Investigation	Investigation Found Subgrantee Made Misrepresentations in its Grant Application and Progress Reports	AmeriCorps	10/28/24
Peer Review of OIG	External Peer Review of FTC OIG by FEC OIG	Federal Trade Commission	9/11/24
Semiannual Report	Semiannual Report to Congress, April 1 - September 30, 2024	National Science Foundation	11/30/24

A 2012 report by the Department of Justice Office of Inspector General illustrates the non-ideological nature of the oversight conducted by OIGs. Entitled “Management of Immigration Cases and Appeals by the Executive Office for Immigration Review” (I-2013-001), the report examined inefficiencies in the management and processing of immigration cases by the Executive Office for Immigration Review (EOIR), a branch of the Department of Justice tasked with, among other things, adjudicating violations of immigration law and deciding whether or not to remove immigrants or grant relief from removal, thus allowing them to stay in the United States. Despite the report focusing on a hot-button political issue, the recommendations in the report aimed to address non-ideological inefficiencies in EOIR’s handling of immigration cases. The recommendations addressed reporting issues in EOIR reports and delays in immigration case adjudication by improving data collection protocols, clarifying the criterion for adjudication, and hiring more staff. Notably, House Appropriations Committee Republicans issued a directive to EOIR to report on their implementation of the OIG’s recommendations in their report accompanying the appropriations bill that would fund the Department of Justice for Fiscal Year 2016 (H.R. 2578).⁶

OIGs often quantify their ‘value’ to politicians and taxpayers by measuring how many dollars of taxpayer money are saved through implemented OIG recommendations relative to the taxpayer dollars spent on the OIG. A report by the Brookings Institute calculated that the mean return on investment for OIGs from 2010-2014 was 13.41, meaning every taxpayer dollar spent on an OIG saved taxpayers \$13.41 in return (Hudak and Wallack 2015). In fiscal year 2014, OIGs recovered \$32 billion from investigations and further questioned \$14 billion in costs through their audits (Johnson 2020). This positive return on investment is often cited by Inspectors General to justify their continued operation, both to politicians and the public (Barrón-López and Popat 2025).

In part because of their role in saving money for the American taxpayer, members of Congress have a clear interest in the work that OIGs conduct. While some OIG audits and investigations are self-initiated, many of them are requested by individual

⁶The full list of recommendations in the report and the full text of the directive are listed in Appendix A.

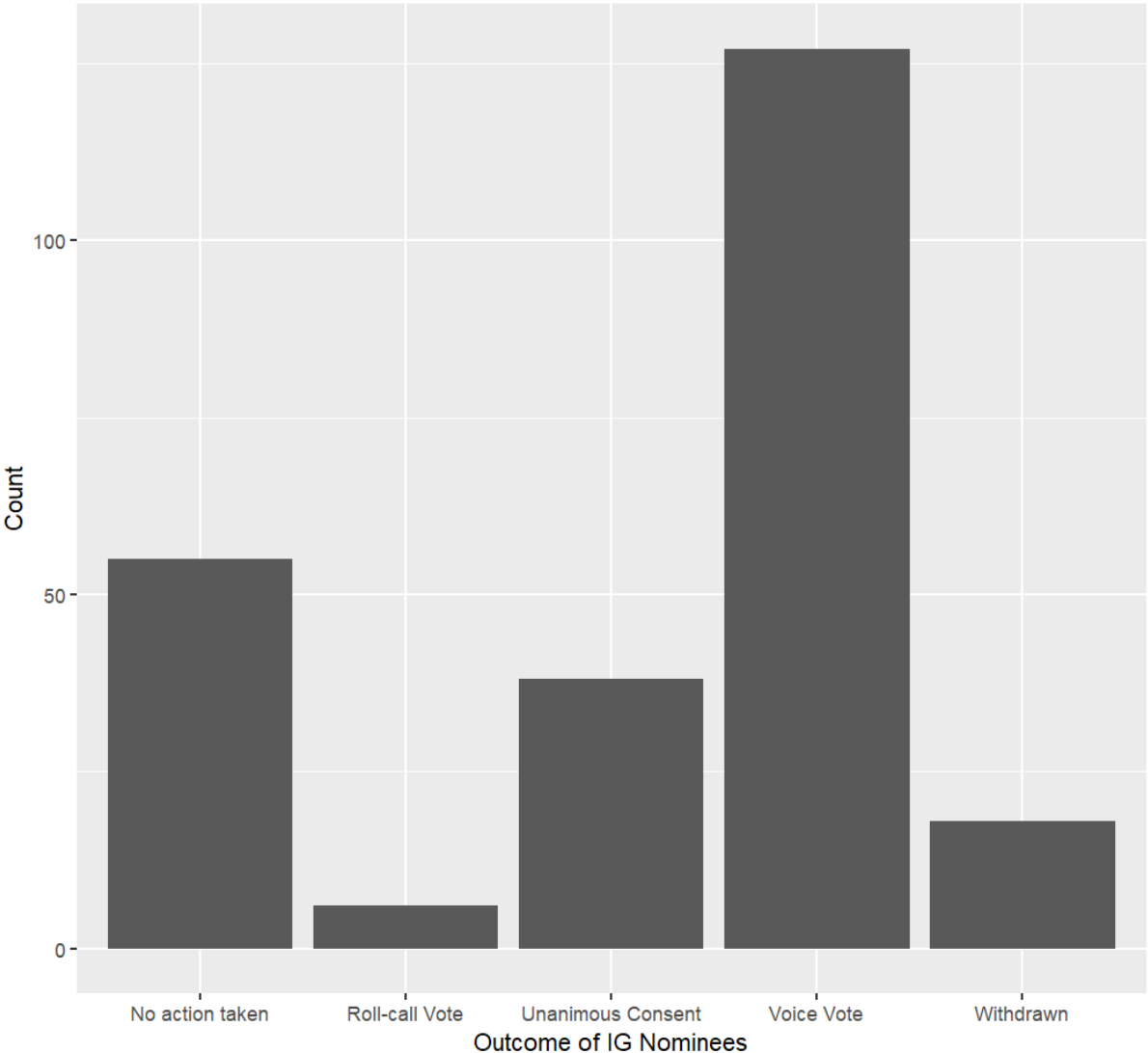
members of Congress. According to a report from the Bipartisan Policy Center, Inspectors General have reported that upwards of 60-80% of their oversight work is mandated and/or requested by Congress (2018).

Support for Inspectors General has also been a traditionally bipartisan point of agreement among members of Congress, pointing to their success at establishing and maintaining a non-partisan image among policymakers. The IG Act received overwhelming bipartisan support, recording only 6 no votes from House members in its only roll-call vote in Congress, and subsequent bills expanding the powers and independence of Inspectors General⁷ have also passed their chambers with little to no dissent (Wilhelm 2023).

Likewise, support for Inspector General nominees has also been highly bipartisan—Figure 1 shows the distribution of outcomes for nominees for these offices, and of the 244 nominees in the data obtained from congress.gov, only 6 had roll-call votes on confirmation, and of those, only 3 faced any significant opposition. Worth noting is that these are just the nominees for agencies with PAS (Presidentially-appointed and Senate confirmed) Inspectors General, which are typically the agencies with the largest budgets and the most policy-making power, thus being where we would expect to see the greatest amount of partisan/ideological divisions on IG nominees. Serving IGs are also not significantly more likely to depart from their role at the start of a presidential term than in the middle or end unlike many political nominations in the executive branch (Johnson 2020). The lack of significant partisan divisions on both IG nominees and bills expanding the powers of OIGs is evidence consistent with OIGs being an institution that conducts oversight on non-ideological issues.

⁷These acts include the Inspector General Act Amendments of 1988, which established a separate appropriations account for OIGs and expanded the number of IGs, the Inspector General Reform Act of 2008, which created the Council of Inspectors General on Integrity and Efficiency (CIGIE), an oversight agency for Inspectors General, as well as the Inspector General Empowerment Act of 2016, which enhanced IG access to data and records from federal agencies. These acts were passed under both Republican and Democratic administrations and Congresses.

Figure 1: Outcomes of PAS Inspector General nominees (1981-2025)



Congress and OIG Oversight

The reason that OIGs have such bipartisan appeal to Congress is their cultivated reputation of being non-ideological, non-partisan oversight agents focused on saving the American taxpayer their hard-earned dollars. Their oversight is crucial for Congress—their location in executive branch agencies themselves gives them a unique informational advantage vis a vis Congress and congressional support organizations, and their non-ideological reputation gives the oversight that they conduct a high degree of bipartisan credibility in a way that in-house congressional oversight does not have. However, this bipartisan credibility does not necessarily shield them from political influence—certainly

not from the agencies they oversee, but also Congress, who has several incentives to manipulate the oversight that they conduct and several tools to make it happen, including tools that affect OIGs' contributions at various stages in congressional oversight.

Why would Congress want to use OIGs to pursue their political oversight goals, and how can they manipulate OIGs accomplish this? I posit that members of Congress are incentivized to manipulate the capacity and oversight agenda of OIGs in accordance with the political environment, in part because the bipartisan credibility of OIG oversight presents opportunities for Congress to politically damage enemies in the executive branch in a way that cannot be done within their own capacities as a political actor with well-known political motives. I then present several methods that Congress can use to achieve their oversight goals using OIGs—OIG budget manipulation, directing OIGs to conduct investigations and directing agencies to implement OIG recommendations, and inviting OIG staff to testify before Congress—and draw empirical predictions for each method that are consistent with a world in which members of Congress use OIG oversight to pursue their political goals, particularly reducing ideological policy drift between Congress and federal agencies.

Political Motivations for Non-Political Oversight

One reason that members of Congress may want to manipulate OIGs is that OIG reports can provide useful political fodder that can further the electoral goals of members of Congress, particularly so given OIGs' non-partisan reputation amongst political actors and the general public. If an agency is revealed to be wasting taxpayer dollars or engaging in corrupt or illegal behavior, it calls into question the competence of the agency and could potentially lead to the resignation of high-ranking agency officials. For example, former Secretary of the Interior Ryan Zinke, who served at the start of the first Trump administration, resigned prematurely after repeated criticism over his improper expenditures in office, such as expensive charter flights and helicopter rides, and his real estate dealings (Eilperin, Dawsey, and Fears 2018). According to a Washington Post article, "...the key moment in his loss of support at the White House came in October,

when Interior’s inspector general referred one of its inquiries to the Justice Department” (2018). Although the reports issued by the Department of Interior’s OIG did not immediately cause Zinke’s resignation, the investigations conducted by the OIG significantly contributed to his political downfall.

The negative effects of a scathing report can have significant political consequences and give the presidential out-party material to cast their opponents as corrupt and fraudulent. When Ryan Zinke ran for the House of Representatives in Montana in 2022, his Democratic opponent, Monica Tranel, made frequent reference to his OIG investigations on the campaign trail, featuring the controversy in one of her TV advertisements. This scandal may have contributed to Zinke’s narrow 3% margin of victory over Tranel, despite running in a conservative-leaning district that he had already represented prior to serving as Secretary of the Interior. Even if the blowback does not directly implicate members of Congress, such as the current Representative Zinke in the aforementioned example, the electoral fates of members of Congress are increasingly tied to the popularity of the current President and their administration (Lee 2008), giving members of Congress electoral incentives to manipulate OIGs in a way that increases/decreases the chances of damaging reports being published depending on their partisan alignment with the President.

These damaging reports can also serve as useful ammunition for Congress to use to attack the reputation and independence of federal agencies, justify implementing preferred policies, and gut funding for federal programs, pursuing the end goal of reducing policy drift between itself and federal agencies. By increasing OIG oversight on opposing agencies and decreasing oversight on allied agencies, Congress can aggressively pursue those agencies most likely to implement policies that Congress disagrees with, reducing policy drift.

Even without the production of damaging reports, an increase in OIG oversight can decrease policy drift. Recall that upwards of 60-80% of OIG oversight is mandated by Congress. Agencies, seeing an uptick in oversight from their assigned OIG, may assume that this increase is being driven by congressionally initiated audits and investigations. This can signal an increase in congressional interest in an agency’s operations

and policymaking—in essence, agencies perceive that they are being watched by Congress. This creates a ‘chilling effect’ that encourages agencies to hew closer to congressional preferences in their general operations, even in areas not currently under audit or investigation by the Inspector General.

Which agencies are most likely to deviate from congressional policy preferences, and thus most likely to have congressional manipulation of their respective OIG’s oversight? Aside from agencies with opposite-party heads appointed by the President, agencies also have a ‘secular’ ideology that may dictate their policymaking. An agency’s secular ideology is the perceived left-right ideological leanings of an agency and its personnel, irrespective of the party of the President/head of the agency (Richardson, Clinton, and Lewis 2018). For example, the EPA, an agency that focuses on environmental regulations, is commonly perceived as an ideologically liberal agency, even when the head of the EPA is a Republican. Republican oversight of the EPA, given its liberal leanings, will bear more fruit in reducing policy drift compared to, say, oversight of the SEC, a conservative-leaning agency.

Another motivation that may drive oversight are political staffing patterns within agencies. Agency politicization is a concept that captures the degree to which the President has influence over the operations and decision-making of a federal agency, often operationalized with data on political appointees within a given agency. Politicization has been found to bias agencies towards presidential co-partisans (Lowande 2019) and reduce agency performance and expertise (Gailmard and Patty 2007, Wood and Lewis 2017, Richardson 2019). If members of Congress conduct oversight with respect to minimizing policy drift, they will focus their attention on politicized agencies when they are in opposition to the President as a way to combat the President’s opposing policy influence. However, if oversight is driven by valence concerns, members of Congress should be most concerned by how politicization reduces agency efficacy and thus conduct oversight of politicized agencies without regard to ideological or partisan divides.

The two parties, thus far, have been treated as the same re: their incentives to conduct oversight, including through OIG manipulation. However, Republicans in Congress,

having stronger preferences for lower government spending than their Democratic counterparts, may find OIG oversight more valuable than Democrats in Congress because of the money saved through the adoption of OIG recommendations by federal agencies. Reagan hinted at this when justifying his firing of the Inspectors General appointed by Carter, stating that he wanted “meaner junkyard dogs” to cut down on federal spending (Light 1993). This does not necessarily mean that Republicans necessarily value policy valence higher than Democrats, it merely means that the taxpayer dollars saved through the adoption of OIG recommendations also achieve an ideological goal of Republicans that they hold in higher regard than Democrats, relatively speaking.

Despite OIG oversight primarily focusing on correcting policy valence, there are several ways in which controlling OIG oversight can achieve the political goals of members of Congress, such as their electoral goals and their ideological policy goals. Partisan opposition to the President, ideological distance from an agency, and identifying with the Republican Party will increase the demand for OIG oversight, and politicization will increase the demand for OIG oversight when in opposition to the President. Table 2 presents a summary of the empirical expectations for each of these political predictors of oversight, broken up into the expectations for when Congress is ideology-focused in its oversight and when Congress is valence-focused.

Table 2: Predictors of OIG Oversight Manipulation

Predictors	Oversight Motivations	
	Ideology	Valence
Presidential Out-party	+	N/A
Agency Politicization	N/A	+
Out-party x Politicization	+	N/A
Congress-Agency Ideological Distance	+	N/A
Republican	+	N/A
GAO High Risk List	N/A	+

Mechanisms for Congressional Control of OIG Oversight

How can members of Congress utilize and manipulate OIG oversight for these aforementioned political goals if OIGs have significant statutory independence and are not even housed in the same branch of government? I examine a few mechanisms for Congress to capitalize on the oversight of OIGs—manipulating OIG budgets, directing OIGs to conduct oversight, directing agencies to implement OIG recommendations, and inviting OIG employees to testify in congressional hearings. The first mechanism involves manipulating the budgets of OIGs to either expand or contract their capacity for oversight. Oversight is costly in a quite literal sense, with OIGs requiring significant sums of money to hire and retain personnel with the time and expertise to conduct audits and write reports. Drolc examines the determinants of the diversity of OIGs’ oversight agenda and finds that an increase in OIG budgets leads to an increase in the issue-area diversity of the oversight agenda (Drolc 2020). A Brookings Institute report also warns of the potential dangers that cutting OIG budgets may have on their oversight capacity, ironically having the potential to grow federal deficits through budget cuts (Hudak and Wallack 2015). Congress, as the body responsible for appropriating money to federal agencies, has the opportunity to strategically manipulate the budgets of OIGs to either increase or decrease their capacity to conduct oversight, thus resulting in a higher/lower likelihood of a damaging OIG report being published, all else held equal.

While adjusting OIG budgets can expand or contract the oversight agenda, it is an imperfect tool for controlling OIG oversight as there is no direct manipulation of what OIGs conduct oversight of. Congress does have a more direct way of controlling OIG oversight—instead of indirectly controlling the agenda of oversight through manipulating capacity, Congress can direct Inspectors General to conduct oversight on specific issues. According to a report by the Bipartisan Policy Center, Inspectors General have reported that upwards of 60-80% of their oversight work is mandated and/or requested by Congress (2018). These directives can be found in laws passed by Congress, in private communications between members of Congress and OIGs, and in committee reports accompanying legislation.

A related method of utilizing OIG oversight to push Congress’s oversight goals, without directly controlling the oversight agenda of OIGs, is through directives to agencies to implement OIG policy recommendations. OIG reports usually have specific policy recommendations that aim to reduce inefficiencies and waste in government operations. OIGs keep track of which recommendations have been implemented in their semi-annual report to Congress, giving Congress specific info about how many recommendations have been given, how many have been implemented, and, if applicable, how much money is projected to be saved by implemented recommendations.

In this paper, I collect and analyze novel data on both categories of directives in appropriations reports. Although directives in appropriations reports are non-statutory, thus not legally binding, Congress regularly uses them to constrain federal agencies, particularly when legislative gridlock is high (Bolton 2022). Inspectors General and federal agencies are strongly incentivized to comply with these directives as Congress can punish them with a reduction in their budget or, in the case of agencies, increased constraints on their policy-making power. Both types of directives can also produce the aforementioned chilling effect, reducing both ideological and valence drift from Congress’s preferences out of fear of punishment from Congress.

Next, I examine witness invitation patterns for committee hearings held by the House Committee on Oversight and Government Reform and the Senate Committee on Homeland Security and Governmental Affairs. Committee hearings are a key opportunity for members of Congress to push their oversight goals, whether it be collecting information on government operations (Diermeier and Feddersen 2000, Ban, Park, and You 2023), reducing policy drift (McGrath 2013), sending political messages to constituents (Park 2021), or some combination of these goals (Eldes, Fong, and Lowande 2024). Committee investigations can also damage public opinion of the President (Kriner and Schickler 2014), making them an effective mechanism for achieving the electoral goals of members of Congress when they are in opposition to the President.

Finally, I utilize data on congressional e-newsletters to look at when members of Congress are communicating information about OIGs to their constituents. By inviting

OIG staff to testify in committee hearings and highlighting the investigatory work of Inspectors General in e-newsletters to constituents, Congress can strategically use the non-partisan reputation of OIGs to pursue their political oversight goals, highlighting a potential complementarity between non-ideological information gathering by OIGs and political signaling by Congress in public-facing venues.

These various methods of OIG control can further the ideological and electoral goals of members of Congress by discouraging agencies from deviating from congressional policy preferences and providing opportunities for Congress to capitalize on OIG oversight when it is politically opportune for them to do so.

OIG Budgets

I estimate the effect of oversight motivations, as shown in Table 2, on OIG oversight capacity by assessing how the budgets of OIGs vary in accordance with the political environment, agency characteristics, and the budget of the agency as a whole. I use the following regression model and ordinary least squares estimation:

$$Y \log(\text{OIG Budget Authority} + 1)_{at+1} = \beta_1 \text{Congressional Characteristics}_t + \beta_2 \text{Agency Characteristics}_{at} + \beta_3 \text{Congressional} \times \text{Agency Characteristics}_{at} + \alpha_a + \alpha_p + \epsilon_{at}$$

where subscript a represents an agency and subscript t represents a year. *Congressional Characteristics* include whether Republicans control the House and Senate (*Rep. House* and *Rep. Senate* respectively) and the number of congressional chambers in opposition to the President. *Agency Characteristics* include the politicization of agency a at year t , the logged budget authority of agency a at year $t + 1$ (excluding OIG budget authority), and the number of entries agency a has on the GAO High Risk list at year t . Finally, *Congressional x Agency Characteristics* includes variables that vary with respect to both Congress and an Agency, including the ideological alignment between the party in control of the House and Senate and a given federal agency as well as the interaction between the number of congressional chambers in opposition to the President and the politicization

of a given agency. I also include Agency and President fixed effects⁸ and report standard errors clustered at the agency level.

Agency and OIG annual budget authority data is sourced from the Office of Management and Budget, with budget numbers adjusted using GDP data from the World Bank to control for inflation. I choose to analyze budget authority⁹ because I am interested in the strategic decision-making that Congress engages in when appropriating money for OIGs. Hammond and Rosenstiel present a critique of using budget outlays to assess the political determinants of the federal budget, as it can take years for authorized money to be spent, making it difficult to connect spending to any particular set of political variables observed at time t (Hammond and Rosenstiel 2020). Budget authority data reduces measurement error, relative to budget outlays, when assessing the effects of the political environment on appropriations.

The GAO High Risk List is published by the Government Accountability Office at the start of every Congress and outlines government programs and agencies at risk of waste, fraud, and abuse, very much in line with the oversight that OIGs do, and the presence of an agency on the list is an indicator that an agency is in need of the kind of oversight that OIGs provide.¹⁰ If the coefficient for this variable is positive, it is evidence in favor of Congress being motivated by non-ideological policy valence concerns.

The data for the agency politicization measure is sourced from the Office of Personnel Management. I follow Lewis's methodology and calculate the ratio of presidentially appointed managers to career civil servant managers for each agency in a given year. This measure calculates how politicized the management structure of an agency is, which is likely a more accurate measure of the degree of presidential influence over agency policy-making and operations given the outsized role that managers play in these areas (Lewis 2008). For agency ideology, I use survey-based ideology scores that measure the extent to

⁸I chose President fixed effects over Congress fixed effects to allow for the analysis of variation with respect to some of the Congress-level variables, such as the parties in control of each chamber. Congress fixed effects would make these key explanatory variables entirely collinear with the fixed effects.

⁹Budget authority refers to money that is authorized by Congress through the appropriations process. This money is available to be spent by a federal agency after entering into a legal agreement to spend the money, known as an obligation.

¹⁰See Appendix B for more information on the GAO High Risk List, how I connected entries on the list with agencies, and descriptive statistics.

which observers view the agency as being ideologically conservative or liberal, regardless of who the current president is (Richardson, Clinton, and Lewis 2018). I interact the ideology scores with the party in control of each chamber of Congress, producing measures where positive values indicate an increase in ideological congruence between agency a and the House or Senate at year t .

I estimate two regression models for OIG budget authority, one on my entire sample of agencies¹¹ and one on just cabinet-level agencies. There may be reason to believe that mandatory spending, such as Social Security and Medicaid, has less room for fraud and waste due to their simplistic distribution process compared to discretionary spending, which can encompass large government projects that can face significant cost overruns due to inefficient spending and performance by government employees and contractors. To account for the potential differences in mandatory and discretionary spending, the models presented in Tables 3 and 4 control for overall agency budget authority. Additional analyses reporting year clustered standard errors and controlling for discretionary agency budget authority can be found in in Appendix E.

¹¹These agencies include every cabinet agency, the Social Security Administration (SSA), the Environmental Protection Agency (EPA), the General Services Administration (GSA), NASA, the Office of Personnel Management (OPM), the Small Business Administration (SBA), the National Science Foundation (NSF), the Nuclear Regulatory Commission (NRC), and AmeriCorps. These are the agencies for which I could obtain data on agency/OIG budget authority, ideology and politicization, though there remains some missingness on the politicization measure even within this sample. See Appendix D for more information on the agencies in each of my analyses.

Table 3: Estimating the Effects of Congressional & Agency Characteristics on OIG Budget Authority (2006-2023)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Rep. House	-0.036+				-0.035+	-0.035+
	(0.020)				(0.020)	(0.020)
Rep. Senate	0.002				0.021	0.021
	(0.013)				(0.016)	(0.016)
# Out-Partisan Chambers		-0.015			-0.016	-0.019
		(0.013)			(0.015)	(0.022)
Agency Politicization			-2.456		-2.364	-2.575
			(3.976)		(3.953)	(4.183)
House-Agency Ideological Alignment				0.018	0.013	0.013
				(0.012)	(0.011)	(0.011)
Senate-Agency Ideological Alignment				0.012	0.014	0.014
				(0.009)	(0.010)	(0.010)
# Out-Partisan Chambers x Agency Politicization						0.196
						(0.695)
log(Agency Budget+1)	0.086**	0.091**	0.088**	0.090**	0.081**	0.081**
	(0.025)	(0.025)	(0.024)	(0.024)	(0.024)	(0.025)
GAO High Risk List	0.017	0.020	0.016	0.018	0.020	0.020
	(0.020)	(0.020)	(0.019)	(0.020)	(0.020)	(0.021)
Observations	381	381	381	381	381	381
R ²	0.977	0.977	0.977	0.977	0.978	0.978
R ² Within	0.112	0.107	0.112	0.117	0.133	0.133
Agency Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
President Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note:

⁺p<0.1; *p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001
Standard errors are clustered by agency.

Table 4: Estimating the Effects of Congressional & Agency Characteristics on OIG Budget Authority (2006-2023) (excluding non-cabinet agencies)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Rep. House	-0.043 (0.025)				-0.047+ (0.026)	-0.048+ (0.026)
Rep. Senate	-0.006 (0.015)				0.009 (0.019)	0.012 (0.019)
# Out-Partisan Chambers		-0.012 (0.014)			-0.014 (0.021)	-0.032 (0.021)
Agency Politicization			-4.016 (5.561)		-3.902 (5.696)	-5.596 (5.766)
House-Agency Ideological Alignment				0.014 (0.015)	0.009 (0.013)	0.009 (0.013)
Senate-Agency Ideological Alignment				0.003 (0.007)	0.004 (0.007)	0.005 (0.007)
# Out-Partisan Chambers x Agency Politicization						1.127** (0.312)
log(Agency Budget+1)	0.111* (0.050)	0.125* (0.046)	0.119* (0.043)	0.123* (0.046)	0.100+ (0.047)	0.103* (0.047)
GAO High Risk List	0.012 (0.020)	0.014 (0.020)	0.013 (0.018)	0.012 (0.020)	0.016 (0.020)	0.016 (0.020)
Observations	234	234	234	234	234	234
R ²	0.927	0.926	0.928	0.926	0.929	0.930
R ² Within	0.099	0.088	0.105	0.092	0.124	0.134
Agency Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
President Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note:

⁺p<0.1; *p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001
Standard errors are clustered by agency.

The results in Tables 3 and 4 do not comport neatly with either set of empirical predictions. The finding for Republican House control is opposite of what was predicted, though the result never reaches full significance and is insignificant in other specifications in Appendix E. The most consistently significant finding is that agency budget authority significantly predicts OIG budget authority, which is to be expected as greater federal spending requires more auditors and investigators to keep tabs on the spending, but the coefficients indicate that only 8-12% of the size of the OIG budget is explained by the amount of spending that they have to oversee. Even when controlling for discretionary agency budget authority in the tables in Appendix E, at most 33% of the OIG budget is explained by the agency's budget authority. This implies that Congress is not single-mindedly focused on policy valence when appropriating money to OIGs, leaving open the door for other factors to influence their decision-making, even if the evidence above is not neatly consistent with our understanding of how politics can affect congressional preferences for oversight.

OIG Directives

Next, I examine two categories of non-statutory directives that I hand-coded instances of in House and Senate Appropriations Committee reports from 2005 to 2024, summing up the counts for each Agency-Year-Chamber triplet. I examine directives to OIGs to conduct audits/investigations of agency operations and directives to agencies to implement OIG recommendations. I also examine whether these directives come with a reporting requirement of some kind, likely reflective of the importance of an issue to Congress. Below, I present examples of each type of directive to explain my coding methodology.

Chemawa Indian School.—The Committee is highly concerned with the findings included in the recent audit published by the Department's Office of Inspector General regarding the financial oversight and management of the Chemawa School in Oregon. Therefore, the Committee directs the Bureau to

brief the Committee within 30 days of enactment of this act on how the Bureau intends to address the issues raised and implement the recommendations included in the audit. (Department of the Interior, Environment, and Related Agencies Appropriations Bill Senate Appropriations Committee Report, July 27th, 2023)

This is an example of a non-statutory directive to an agency to implement OIG recommendations with a reporting requirement attached. This directive is for the Department of the Interior's Bureau of Indian Affairs to implement the recommendations issued in a DOI OIG report raising red flags about the financial governance of a Native American boarding school. Once again, this directive comes with a reporting requirement where the Bureau is directed to report to the Senate Appropriations Committee within 30 days of enactment on their progress implementing the recommendations listed in the report. These directives also allow Congress to intensify oversight on the agencies and programs that it wishes to conduct the most oversight of.

Mail Collection Box Removal.—The Committee directs the USPS OIG to conduct an audit of the mail collection box removal process and brief the Committee no later than 30 days after enactment of this Act. (Financial Services and General Government Appropriations Bill House Appropriations Committee Report, June 17th, 2024)

This is an example of a non-statutory directive to an OIG to conduct an investigation. In this case, the committee is directing the United States Postal Service (USPS) OIG to audit the process by which USPS decides when to remove mail collection boxes, which are sites where people can drop off mail to be delivered. The directive comes with a reporting requirement, specifically to update the House Appropriations Committee with their findings within 30 days of the implementation of the act. By issuing these directives, Congress can manipulate the oversight agenda of OIGs towards the agencies and programs that they want to conduct the most oversight of, whether it be for political or non-political reasons.

Both of these categories of directives often reoccur from year-to-year. Therefore, the presence of, for example, 5 directives to the EPA in both 2006 and 2007 does not necessarily mean 5 unique directives for each year. However, the repeated inclusion, and subsequent dropping, of these directives is still informative about the relative intensity of oversight that Congress wants each agency to feel subject to. Likewise, not every directive has a reporting requirement attached to it, so the presence of a reporting requirement is informative about the relative intensity of oversight that Congress would like to conduct. More information about the data collection process, as well as descriptive tables, is in Appendix C.

I use the counts of these directives and the counts of directives with reporting requirements to assess the same aforementioned empirical predictors in Table 2. I use the following regression model and ordinary least squares estimation:

$$Y\text{Directives}_{act} = \beta_1\text{Chamber Characteristics}_{ct} + \beta_2\text{Agency Characteristics}_{at} + \beta_3\text{Congressional Characteristics}_t + \beta_4\text{Chamber x Agency Characteristics}_{act} + \alpha_a + \alpha_p + \epsilon_{act}$$

where subscript a represents an agency, subscript c represents a chamber in Congress, and t represents a year. *Chamber Characteristics* contains variables capturing political motivations for oversight such as whether the chamber that issued the directive is of the opposite party of the current President and whether the chamber is controlled by Republicans. I also control for whether the chamber issuing the directive is the Senate to control for confounding differences between the two chambers, such as the fact that the House is the first mover in the appropriations process.¹² *Agency Characteristics* include the same variables as the budget analysis (agency politicization and number of entries on the GAO High Risk List) as well as the number of OIG audit reports issued for that agency in year $t - 1$. I posit that the number of OIG audit reports is informative as to the number of ‘problems’ being identified by OIGs within a given agency,¹³ so I include this

¹²Since the directives in the appropriations reports are only issued by two committees, that being each chamber’s respective appropriations committee, the Senate dummy variable in the regression is equivalent to committee fixed effects.

¹³For agencies where I was able to gather data on the number of new recommendations in each semi-annual report, the correlation between the number of audit reports issued and the number of new rec-

variable in the analysis to assess if these directives are being driven by the need for more OIG audits and implementation of OIG recommendations, in line with a valence-based perspective on oversight. This data was collected from the mandated semi-annual reports published every 6 months by every OIG and submitted to Congress.

Congressional Characteristics includes whether the two chambers of Congress are controlled by opposite parties (Divided Chambers) to capture whether legislative gridlock increases reliance on non-statutory directives, in line with findings from Bolton (2022). Finally, *Chamber $\times$ Agency Characteristics* includes the ideological alignment between the agency and the chamber of Congress issuing the directive as well as the interaction between agency politicization and whether the chamber of Congress is in opposition to the President. Like the budget analysis, I include agency and President fixed effects and report clustered standard errors at the agency level. Tables 5 and 6 report the results for the directives to both agencies and OIGs with reporting requirements. The results for overall directives without conditioning on reporting requirements, as well as specifications of the models with year clustered standard errors, can be found in Appendix F.

ommendations was 0.596, even without accounting for agency heterogeneity.

Table 5: Effects of Congressional and Agency Characteristics on directives to agency to implement OIG recommendations with reporting requirement (2005-2024)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Presidential Out-Party	0.079 (0.084)				0.066 (0.077)	0.101 (0.106)
Agency Politicization		4.339 (4.100)			3.154 (4.527)	4.548 (4.935)
Chamber-Agency Ideological Alignment			0.064 (0.040)		0.062 (0.046)	0.063 (0.046)
Republican				-0.037 (0.089)	0.004 (0.092)	0.003 (0.092)
Presidential Out-Party x Agency Politicization						-2.280 (2.872)
Senate					-0.001 (0.101)	-0.001 (0.101)
Divided Chambers					0.023 (0.058)	0.019 (0.058)
$\log(\text{Audit Reports} + 1) \ t - 1$	-0.151 (0.152)	-0.179 (0.156)	-0.181 (0.155)	-0.181 (0.155)	-0.155 (0.148)	-0.159 (0.150)
GAO High Risk List	0.041 (0.162)	0.051 (0.165)	0.053 (0.163)	0.048 (0.167)	0.047 (0.169)	0.046 (0.169)
Observations	794	794	794	794	794	794
R ²	0.301	0.301	0.302	0.301	0.304	0.304
R ² Within	0.005	0.005	0.006	0.004	0.008	0.009
Agency Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
President Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note:

⁺p<0.1; *p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001
Standard errors are clustered by agency.

Table 6: Effects of Congressional and Agency Characteristics on directives to OIG to conduct audit/investigation with reporting requirement (2005-2024)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Presidential Out-Party	0.044 (0.073)				0.032 (0.056)	0.070 (0.080)
Agency Politicization		6.312* (2.512)			5.611* (2.585)	7.098+ (3.866)
Chamber-Agency Ideological Alignment			-0.026 (0.035)		-0.049 (0.043)	-0.049 (0.044)
Republican				-0.052 (0.092)	-0.081 (0.111)	-0.082 (0.111)
Presidential Out-Party x Agency Politicization						-2.432 (3.686)
Senate					0.001 (0.062)	0.001 (0.062)
Divided Chambers					0.025 (0.063)	0.020 (0.061)
$\log(\text{Audit Reports} + 1) \ t - 1$	-0.032 (0.054)	-0.048 (0.054)	-0.047 (0.055)	-0.051 (0.055)	-0.036 (0.054)	-0.040 (0.054)
GAO High Risk List	0.261** (0.084)	0.267** (0.083)	0.265** (0.083)	0.263** (0.082)	0.258** (0.079)	0.257** (0.078)
Observations	794	794	794	794	794	794
R ²	0.301	0.301	0.302	0.301	0.304	0.304
R ² Within	0.005	0.005	0.006	0.004	0.008	0.009
Agency Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
President Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note:

⁺p<0.1; *p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001
Standard errors are clustered by agency.

The results for directives to agencies to implement OIG recommendations with reporting requirements in Table 5 are entirely statistically null, which makes it difficult to draw any conclusions about the motivations behind the usage of these directives. However, when examining directives to OIGs in Table 6, the coefficient for the GAO High Risk List is highly significant, even with agency fixed effects. The independent effect of agency politicization is substantively large¹⁴ and signed in the correct direction and, combined with the null effect of the interaction term, is evidence that Congress hews closer towards policy valence considerations than political considerations when directing OIGs to conduct investigations of federal agencies. This is consistent with the content of OIG audits and investigations being non-ideological in nature.

OIG Staff in Congressional Hearings

In this section, I examine when OIG staff, including Inspectors General and their affiliated staffers, are invited to testify before Congress. Congressional hearings are used for both gathering important information on agency operations and legislation (Diermeier and Feddersen 2000, Ban, Park, and You 2023) and political messaging by members of Congress (Park 2021, Eldes, Fong, and Lowande 2024), making them a useful tool for members of Congress to pursue their oversight goals, political or otherwise. By inviting OIG staff to testify before Congress about their oversight efforts, Congress can pursue its political goals by capitalizing on agency waste, fraud, and abuse for electoral and policy gains.

Pending a more robust data collection effort, I present preliminary results with OIG witness invitation data for the House Committee on Oversight and Government Reform and the Senate Committee on Homeland Security and Governmental Affairs from 2005 to 2022.¹⁵ I chose these committees because they have universal oversight jurisdiction over

¹⁴The values of politicization in the dataset range from 0 to 0.1023, so a move from the lowest to the highest value of politicization results in an increase of roughly 0.7 additional directives with a reporting requirement per agency-chamber-year observation.

¹⁵Within this time period, OIG staffers were invited to testify before the House and Senate Oversight Committees 461 times and the heads of each OIG, the Inspector General, were invited to testify 310 times. Table 26 in Appendix H has a breakdown of witness invitations by OIG.

the federal government, meaning that they are not limited to oversight of any particular federal agency in the way that other committees are, and they also conduct the most oversight of the executive branch of any committee (Dodd and Schott 1979, Parker and Dull 2013). I collect this data on witness invitation patterns using the Statements of Activities reports for both of the oversight committees from the 109th to 117th Congresses.

I conduct the analysis at the agency-chamber-year unit of analysis where the outcome variable is the number of times an employee of a given agency’s OIG office¹⁶ is invited to testify before Congress by a chamber of Congress in a given year. I choose this unit of analysis because it preserves the ability to analyze witness invitations with respect to agency-level variables such as politicization and ideology. Conducting the analysis at the hearing level would make it difficult to analyze important agency-level variables, particularly when a hearing invites multiple OIG staffers to testify. However, for completeness’s sake, I conduct another analysis of OIG witness invitation patterns at the hearing level using congressional hearing data from the Comparative Agendas Project (Jones et al. 2025). The results are presented in Table 30 in Appendix H.

I use the following regression model and ordinary least squares estimation:

$$Y\#OIG\text{ Witnesses Testifying}_{act} = \beta_1\text{Chamber Characteristics}_{ct} + \beta_2\text{Agency Characteristics}_{at} + \beta_3\text{Chamber x Agency Characteristics}_{act} + \alpha_a + \alpha_p + \epsilon_{act}$$

where subscript a represents an agency, subscript c represents a chamber in Congress, and subscript t represents a year. The political and valence variables are largely the same as the directives analyses in Tables 5 and 6, with the addition of a control variable for annual committee staff numbers to capture committee-level oversight and a control variable for the total number of hearings held by a committee within a given Congress. I cluster at the agency level and include President and agency fixed effects as before. The results are presented below in Table 7, with alternative specifications in Appendix H.

¹⁶Certain agencies, such as the Department of Treasury, are overseen by multiple OIGs—both the Department of Treasury OIG and the Special Inspector General for Tax Administration oversee Treasury operations, with the latter focusing on oversight of the Internal Revenue Service. This is rare, but for the purposes of analysis, I aggregate observations associated with each of these smaller OIGs to their appropriate parent agency.

Table 7: OIG Witness Invitation Patterns for House and Senate Oversight Committee Hearings (2005-2022)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Presidential Out-Party	-0.013 (0.060)				-0.011 (0.060)	-0.029 (0.069)
Politicization		0.280 (1.880)			0.268 (1.889)	-0.357 (1.671)
Chamber-Agency Ideological Alignment			-0.006 (0.058)		0.048 (0.067)	0.048 (0.067)
Republican				0.184* (0.073)	0.220+ (0.107)	0.221+ (0.107)
Presidential Out-Party x Politicization						1.154 (3.893)
Senate	-0.245* (0.112)	-0.240+ (0.116)	-0.240+ (0.118)	-0.224+ (0.114)	-0.228* (0.109)	-0.228* (0.109)
Committee Staff	0.001 (0.002)	0.001 (0.002)	0.001 (0.002)	0.001 (0.002)	0.001 (0.002)	0.001 (0.002)
Total Hearings Held	0.002 (0.001)	0.002 (0.001)	0.002 (0.001)	0.002 (0.001)	0.002 (0.001)	0.002 (0.001)
GAO High Risk List	-0.026 (0.112)	-0.027 (0.111)	-0.028 (0.109)	-0.018 (0.109)	-0.012 (0.108)	-0.011 (0.108)
$\log(\text{Audit Reports}+1) \ t - 1$	-0.059 (0.109)	-0.056 (0.107)	-0.056 (0.106)	-0.053 (0.104)	-0.054 (0.109)	-0.052 (0.108)
Observations	794	794	794	794	794	794
R ²	0.272	0.272	0.272	0.280	0.281	0.281
R ² Within	0.037	0.037	0.037	0.047	0.049	0.049
Agency Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
President Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note:

⁺p<0.1; *p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001
Standard errors are clustered by agency.

As shown in Table 7, the agency-level variables best capturing a valence motivation for oversight, the count of audit reports at $t - 1$ and entries on the GAO High Risk List, are statistically null. However, Republicans are significantly more likely to invite OIG staffers to testify before Congress—a Republican-controlled oversight committee will, on average, invite 5.3 more OIG staffers to testify per year than a Democratic-controlled oversight committee. This result also holds true when standard errors are clustered by year—the results for this analysis are in Appendix H. Likewise, the limited hearing-level analysis in Table 30 in Appendix H is also indicative of political factors driving OIG witness invitations, including presidential opposition and Republican control of Congress. This result, combined with an insignificant result on other political and valence variables, is congruent with a world in which Republicans prioritize the work that OIGs do over Democrats because they place a higher value on trimming government spending than Democrats. Alternatively, because of the public-facing nature of committee hearings, this result may also reflect a desire among Republicans to pander to anti-government views among their constituents. Regardless, this result is not particularly consistent with the literature’s understanding of the political motivations of congressional oversight, including in congressional hearings, which tend to find a positive effect of presidential opposition or ideological divergence between Congress and an agency on oversight intensity (McGrath 2013, Parker and Dull 2013, among others).

OIGs in Congressional E-Newsletters

In this section, I utilize the DCInbox dataset of congressional e-newsletters (Cormack 2017) to examine when members of Congress mention Inspectors General in e-newsletters they write for their constituents. These e-newsletters are a way for members of Congress to communicate directly with their constituents via email and contain messaging on all sorts of issues that push forward the electoral goals of members of Congress. Members will comment on key votes they’ve taken, claim credit for legislative and pork wins, and highlight constituent service in these e-newsletters. An average member of Congress will send around 25 of these e-newsletters a year, making them a frequent and direct avenue

of communication between members of Congress and their constituents.

I posit that these e-newsletters are also a key mechanism through which members of Congress will share information related to the executive branch with their constituents, including information produced by Inspectors General. Much like with committee hearings, members of Congress can selectively highlight reports and other forms of information produced by Inspectors General when it is congruent with their electoral goals, such as when they are in opposition to the President. These e-newsletters also have the advantage of being directly targeted towards constituents, making these e-newsletters an ideal case for examining whether members of Congress engage in political targeting in the information-sharing part of oversight.

How do members of Congress talk about Inspectors General in these e-newsletters? Take the case of a General Services Administration (GSA) scandal from 2012. The GSA OIG published an investigation report on April 2, 2012 entitled “Western Regions Conference Management Deficiency Report”, outlining wasteful spending on a regional conference by the Public Buildings Service branch of the General Services Administration. The conference was held at the luxurious M Resort Spa Casino in Las Vegas and over \$800k was spent on the conference, including spending \$3200 on a mind-reader and \$75000 on a team-building exercise to repair a bicycle. The report resulted in GSA administrator Martha Johnson resigning from her position (Rein and Davidson 2012).

Notably, the report was requested by GSA Deputy Administrator Susan Brita, an Obama appointee who had previously served as a Democratic congressional committee staffer from 1992 to 2010. Despite that, of the 8 members of Congress who brought up the scandal in their e-newsletters in the month following the report, 7 of them were Republicans. The only Democrat who commented on the scandal in an e-newsletter represented a district that would give Mitt Romney 69% of the vote for President later that year. This in of itself is suggestive evidence that members of Congress selected into whether or not to speak about this scandal on the basis of whether or not they were in opposition to President Obama, a Democrat.

Jeff Denham (R-CA) 4/6/12: “As you know, I am always looking for ways to save

taxpayers' dollars, which is why I introduced the Civilian Property Realignment Act, which passed in the House of Representatives in February this year and saves \$1.7 billion annually by getting rid of unused properties held by the General Services Administration (GSA). This week, the appalling, unauthorized spending habits of the GSA came to light, causing top officials and the Administrator to resign or be fired. A recent inspector general report showed that GSA officials spent almost a million dollars on a lavish Las Vegas conference for a few hundred bureaucrats-including costs for a clown and a mind-reader. My colleagues on the House Committee on Transportation and Infrastructure will get to the bottom of this waste in a hearing on April 19th. As Committee Chairman John Mica (R-FL) said, "This is just the tip of the iceberg." The GSA has habitually mismanaged taxpayer owned assets, and I am determined to find out just how much they have taken advantage of the American people through unauthorized and extravagant spending. You can see my comments on Fox News and CNN [here](#)."

Jim Matheson (D-UT) 4/20/12: "Dear (Name), Like you, I was outraged to learn of the excessive, wasteful and impermissible spending by some federal employees at a conference held in Las Vegas in 2010. Oversight hearings are underway this week in Congress. The chief of the General Services Administration has resigned, two of her deputies have been fired, and others have been suspended. An Inspector General's report concludes the agency "followed neither federal procurement laws not its own policy on conference spending." As public servants, we all have a duty to be careful stewards of taxpayer dollars. I am following the investigations closely and I am constantly working to ferret out government waste, fraud and abuse."

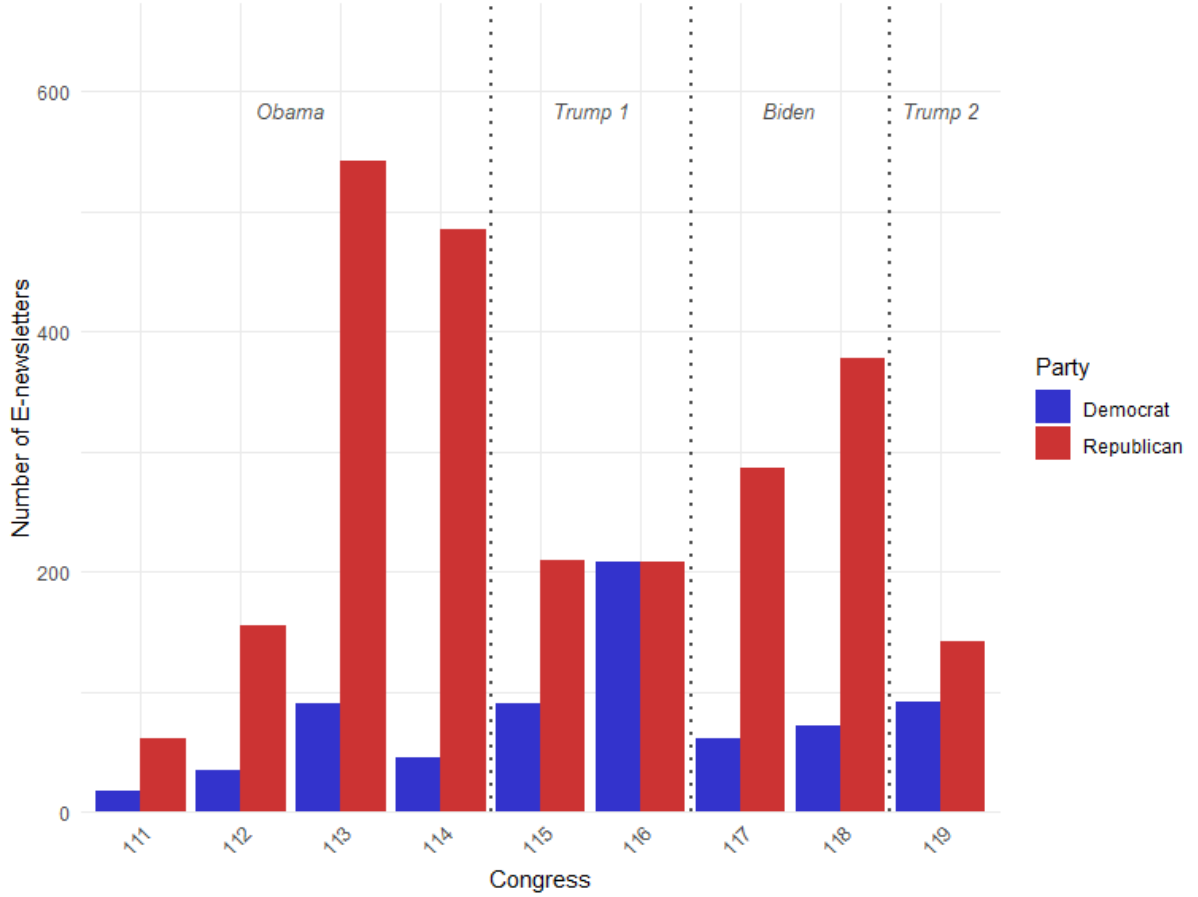
The descriptive examples shown above highlight some clear differences: Compared to the e-newsletter from Democrat Jim Matheson, the e-newsletter penned by Republican Jeff Denham is longer, has explicit references to the dollar amounts of waste referenced in the Inspector General report, and uses the scandal to highlight specific legislative priorities. It is clear in this example that Republicans not only spoke more often about the scandal to their constituents but were more vocal and critical in their opposition than even other Democrats who spoke about the same scandal.

The commonality between these two examples is that the mention of the scandal induced by the Inspector General report implicates the Obama administration in corrupt practices, even if Obama was not mentioned by name in either of these e-newsletters. For Republicans looking to increase their numbers in Congress and take over the White House, mentioning this scandal to their constituents can mobilize them to vote out the current administration, achieving their electoral goals, whereas Democrats have the opposite incentive as their re-election chances are closely tied to the success of the Obama administration. It is telling that the lone Democrat who mentioned this scandal in their e-newsletters in the month following the report was a conservative Democrat who represented a heavily Republican district in Utah, making him one of a small number of congressional Democrats who had clear electoral incentives to criticize the Obama administration.

Beyond this example, descriptive trends suggest that members of Congress are strategic in referencing Inspectors General in their e-newsletters. Figure 2 shows that the number of Republican e-newsletters that mention Inspectors General¹⁷ are cut by over half following the transition from the Obama to the first Trump presidency, with a similar pattern for the Biden to the second Trump presidency with the caveat of only partial data for the 119th Congress. Republicans are also more likely to mention Inspectors General than Democrats in general, with 78% of e-newsletters mentioning Inspectors General coming from Republicans despite Republicans only authoring 62% of total e-newsletters across this timespan. Both of these descriptive trends are congruent with the political predictors laid out in Table 2 and correspond with politically motivated oversight.

¹⁷I construct this measure of Inspectors General mentions by looking for mentions of words in a dictionary of Inspectors General words—these words include ‘Inspector General’, ‘IG’, ‘OIG’, ‘SIGTARP’, ‘TIGTA’, ‘ICIG’, ‘SIGPR’, and ‘SIGAR’.

Figure 2: Number of Congressional E-newsletters referencing Inspectors General by Party (2010-2026)



Note: Partial data only for the 111th (2010 onwards) and 119th (2025-May 2026) congresses

Next, I utilize the e-newsletter data from DCInbox to test the predictions in Table 2 in a series of fixed-effects regression models with the following structure and least square estimation:

$$\text{YIG Mention}_e = \beta_1 \text{Member Characteristics}_{em} + \alpha_m + \alpha_t + \epsilon_{emt}$$

where subscript e represents an individual e-newsletter, subscript m represents a member of Congress, and subscript t represents a congress. The regression model includes member and congress fixed effects and standard errors are clustered at the member level. I include a series of predictors and controls from the Center for Effective Lawmaking

dataset (Volden and Wiseman 2014), including whether a member is a committee chair, the vote percentage that the member received in the last election, and a member’s legislative effectiveness score, to rule out potential confounding relationships. The results are presented below in Table 8.

Table 8: Predictors of Inspectors General mentions in congressional e-newsletters (2010-2024)

	(1)	(2)
Presidential Out-Party	0.007*** (0.001)	0.006*** (0.001)
Senate		-0.002 (0.008)
Committee Chair		0.003 (0.004)
Subcommittee Chair		0.004* (0.002)
Vote percent in last election		0.000 (0.000)
Majority Party		-0.002 (0.001)
Majority Party Leader		-0.001 (0.002)
Minority Party Leader		0.002 (0.003)
Seniority		-0.001 (0.001)
LES 1.0		0.001 (0.001)
Observations	192504	192504
R ²	0.028	0.030
Member Fixed Effects	✓	✓
Congress Fixed Effects	✓	✓

Note:

⁺p<0.1; *p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001
Standard errors are clustered by member of Congress.

On average, a member of Congress being in opposition to the President results in a 53% increase in the probability of an e-newsletter containing a mention of an Inspector General. Though the baseline probability that an individual newsletter containing a mention of an Inspector General is relatively low at around 1.5%, this effect translates to dozens more newsletters mentioning Inspectors General when aggregating up to the congress-party level.

This evidence strongly supports the notion that members of Congress strategically publicize information about Inspectors General oversight when it is in their best electoral interest to criticize the incumbent administration. This is despite members of Congress

refraining from politicizing the budgets or oversight agendas of Inspectors General, which highlights the strategy that members of Congress engage in: Members of Congress preserve the credibility of Inspectors General by protecting their political independence and then subsequently leverage this credibility to engage in political targeting of the executive branch, which they achieve by selectively discussing Inspectors General and the information they uncover when it is in their best electoral interests to do so. This strategy showcases how ideological and non-ideological oversight are not just separate strategies conducted in different venues, but can complement each other under the right circumstances.

Discussion

The inconsistent results across the four sets of analyses of congressional manipulation of OIG oversight—budgets, directives, witness invitations and mentions in e-newsletters—perhaps point to differing levels of importance for political motivations across different modes of congressional oversight. Lowande, in his work on private communications between Congress and federal agencies, posits that electoral and ideological motivations only motivate oversight in public settings, with private oversight being motivated by valence concerns, because of the incentives for members of Congress to pander to their constituents when oversight is public (2018). The fact that an ideological motivation for oversight only appears in the two public-facing analyses, the witness analysis and e-newsletter analysis, whereas valence predictors are more informative of oversight intensity in the directives analysis, is congruent with this understanding of when politics drives congressional oversight.

Why does Congress not politicize OIG oversight at every stage of the process? Referring back to Selin and Moore’s operationalization of oversight as “a series of actions designed both to gather information on the executive and to facilitate legislative credit claiming and position taking” (187, 2023), OIGs can contribute to both information provision and political posturing for members of Congress. What makes the information produced by OIG oversight different than, say, information produced by members of

Congress and their staff, is the non-partisan credibility that comes with their political independence. The ability for Congress to use the information gathered by OIGs for credit claiming and position taking is contingent on OIGs retaining their credibility with the public and relevant stakeholders. Politicizing OIG oversight will ‘poison the well’, so to speak, and make the trustworthiness of the information produced by OIGs suspect, making OIG information no more useful than information gathered by Congress or congressional staffers. On top of that, the presence of several actors in Congressional oversight, including members of Congress themselves, congressional staffers, the Government Accountability Office, and several non-governmental actors, means that Congress does not need to politicize the information gathering of OIG offices to pursue political oversight of the executive branch.

The inconsistent results throughout the ‘process’ of OIG oversight also underline the importance of understanding congressional oversight as a multi-stage process (Selin and Moore 2023).¹⁸ Many committee hearings have their roots in reports written by congressional staffers or another actor with oversight responsibilities, such as OIGs, and the information-gathering process that produces these reports is itself dictated by the oversight and reporting structures that Congress sets up in statute and engages in on its own whim. Congress is constantly receiving information about government operations from a variety of sources and Congress must decide which information to use in a hearing or some other public-facing form of oversight with full knowledge of the political gain that public oversight of each of these agencies provides them (Aberbach 1990).

However, most empirical studies of congressional oversight examine one form of oversight in isolation, such as congressional hearings or private communications. The variation in the importance of electoral and ideological incentives in explaining oversight intensity are a result of the differing incentives present in each of these forms of oversight, as mentioned earlier with Lowande’s study on direct communications with agencies (2018). Likewise, most studies of congressional oversight only focus on ‘in-house’ oversight con-

¹⁸I do not claim that oversight is a strict step-by-step process that is followed in every case, but there is a general flow of oversight where information gathering by agents, such as congressional staffers, OIGs, and the GAO, happen before public-facing oversight by members of Congress, such as the publication of reports and the holding of hearings.

ducted by members of Congress and their staffers, missing out on a large chunk of oversight conducted at the earlier stages in the oversight process where information about agency operations must be gathered.

One consequence of this focus on singular modes of ‘in-house’ oversight is that the field’s theoretical understanding of how politics/policy valence drive oversight does not take into account how valence-focused oversight can produce politically beneficial outcomes for Congress. Though the evidence in this paper is not dispositive of this, there is reason to believe that Congress does not necessarily need to engage in political manipulation of up-stream information gathering, such as manipulating OIG budgets or selectively directing OIGs to investigate out-partisan agencies, to reap the electoral and ideological benefits of oversight. This is in part because Congress has discretion over whether to ‘escalate’ findings about federal agency misconduct from one of their agents, be it staffers, OIGs, or the GAO, into a more public setting like committee hearings where members of Congress can pander to their electorate. In fact, politicizing up-stream oversight can potentially hurt the political value of oversight for Congress, as the trustworthiness of the information produced by Congress’s oversight agents, including OIGs, is conditioned on their political independence and trustworthiness in the eyes of the public. Therefore, the lack of empirical patterns consistent with politically-minded oversight, particularly in more private and ‘early’ forms of oversight, does not exclude the possibility that Congress is nonetheless acting in its best political interests.

Conclusion

By examining congressional manipulation of Office of Inspector General (OIG) oversight, I contribute to the literature by identifying variation in oversight incentives for members of Congress across different modes of oversight, validating the importance of understanding congressional oversight as a process. Though the results are noisy, there is some evidence that Congress uses OIG oversight to fulfill their ideological and electoral goals when the opportunity to publicize their oversight is present, specifically through inviting OIG staff to testify before Congress and highlighting the oversight work they

conduct in e-newsletters to their constituents. However, political factors are far less important at explaining variation in OIG budgets and directives given to OIGs and agencies in appropriations reports, which imply that Congress refrains from manipulating the agenda and capacity of OIGs to pursue their ideological and electoral goals.

By preserving the capacity and independence of OIGs, the information OIGs produce through oversight remains trustworthy to both Congress and the public, thus allowing Congress to use this information to pursue their ideological and electoral goals as well as pressure agencies to be responsive to the non-ideological interest of reducing government waste, fraud, and abuse. These results suggest a complementarity between conducting oversight in accordance with minimizing policy valence, particularly in the information gathering process of oversight, and capitalizing on the information produced by this oversight to reap electoral gains, which is a distinct understanding of how politics affects congressional oversight than has been previously discussed in the literature. Much work is left to be done on theorizing about, and empirically testing, how different congressional oversight mechanisms can work with each other to satisfy Congress's oversight goals.

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A Department of Justice OIG Report Information

Table 9: Recommendations in October 2012 DOJ OIG report (I-2013-001)

Number	Recommendation	Status*
Rec. 1	EOIR improve reporting of immigration court data to distinguish decisions on the removal of aliens from other case activities and reflect actual case length even when more than one court is involved.	Resolved
Rec. 2	EOIR eliminate case exemptions from completion goals to reflect actual case length, but identify case delays that EOIR considers outside the control of immigration judges.	Resolved
Rec. 3	EOIR develop immigration court case completion goals for non-detained cases.	Resolved
Rec. 4	EOIR analyze reasons for continuances and develop guidance that provides immigration judges with standards and guidelines for granting continuances to avoid unnecessary delays.	Unresolved
Rec. 5	EOIR develop a process for tracking time that immigration judges spend on different types of cases and work activities.	Resolved
Rec. 6	EOIR collect and track data on its use of staffing details of judges.	Resolved
Rec. 7	EOIR develop an objective staffing model to assist in determining staffing requirements and the allocation of positions among immigration courts.	Resolved
Rec. 8	EOIR consider seeking additional resources or reallocating resources to reduce delays in the processing of appeals for non-detained aliens.	Unresolved
Rec. 9	EOIR improve its collecting, tracking, and reporting of BIA appeal statistics to accurately reflect actual appeal processing times.	Resolved

*Recommendation status as of the publication of the report

Management of cases and appeals.—The Committee is aware that the Office of Inspector General (OIG) in an October 2012 report (I-2013-001) recommended ways to streamline immigration hearing proceedings, specifically the need for consistent tracking mechanisms that avoid double counting cases which occur when a person is transferred between jurisdictions to a different IJ team. The Committee directs EOIR to brief the Committee not later than 90 days after enactment of this Act on the status of the implementation of these recommendations. (Commerce, Justice, Science and Related Agencies Appropriations Bill House Appropriations Committee Report, May 27th, 2015)

B GAO High Risk List Coding Process & Descriptive Tables

The GAO High Risk List is published by the Government Accountability Office at the start of every Congress in January-April. Each report has roughly 30 or so entries detailing federal agencies and programs at the highest risk for waste, fraud, and abuse. For each publication from 2005-2025, I read the report associated with each entry and determined which federal agencies, if any, were the focus of the given entry by seeing if the text of the report discussed a given agency's operations and/or policies. Entries were aggregated at the highest level of agency (i.e. an entry focusing on the Transportation Security Administration was coded as an entry focusing on its parent agency, the Department of Homeland Security). Some entries were fairly self-explanatory, such as "NASA Contract Management", which is coded as an entry for NASA only. Others were more nuanced and focused on operations and policies from multiple agencies, such as "Improving Federal Management of Programs that Serve Tribes and Their Members", which focuses on ways in which the Bureau for Indian Affairs, a sub-agency of the Department of the Interior (DOI), and the Indian Health Service, an operating division of the Department of Health and Human Services (HHS), can improve provision of government services to Native Americans, including healthcare and education. This entry was coded for both DOI and HHS. Finally, some entries were broad and did not have a particular focus on a singular agency or set of agencies, and those entries were coded as N/As. Table 10 has the number of entries for each agency that appeared at least once in the GAO High Risk List in the time period from 2005 to 2025.

Table 10: GAO High Risk List entries by Agency and Congress (2005-2025)

Agency	109	110	111	112	113	114	115	116	117	118	119
DHS	1	3	3	3	4	4	4	4	5	5	6
DOC	0	1	2	1	3	3	4	3	3	2	2
DOD	8	9	9	8	8	8	9	8	7	7	7
DOE	1	1	1	1	1	1	2	2	2	2	2
DOI	0	0	0	1	1	1	2	2	2	2	2
DOJ	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	2	2
DOL	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	1
DOT	1	2	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
ED	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	1	1
EPA	0	0	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
FDIC	0	0	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
FED	0	0	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
FHFA	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	1	1	1
HHS	2	3	4	4	4	4	5	5	6	7	7
HUD	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
NASA	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
PBGC	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	0	0
SBA	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	1	1
SSA	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
STATE	0	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
TREAS	2	3	4	4	3	3	3	3	3	3	3
USDA	0	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
USPS	1	0	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
VA	1	1	1	1	1	2	2	3	3	3	3
<i>N/A</i>	5	5	5	5	4	5	4	5	5	5	5

C Directives Coding Process & Descriptive Tables

To code non-statutory directives in appropriations committee reports, I gathered the House and Senate appropriations reports from congress.gov, when available, for each subcommittee’s initial version of an appropriations bill from fiscal years 2006 to 2025. Some reports were missing due to the development of certain appropriations bills being unorthodox and thus resulting in one chamber not producing a report for a given year. I then conducted a keyword search of ‘OIG’, ‘Inspector’, and ‘IG’ using the PDF viewer program Okular which allows for keyword searches of multiple words at the same time, thus capturing any mention of an Inspector General, an Office of Inspector General, and/or work conducted by an OIG in the report. I manually counted the number of directives that fit within the two main categories and then assessed whether the directive contained a reporting requirement or not.

The first main category is directives that direct an agency to implement policy recommendations issued by an OIG. My process in this was assessing whether the recommendations mentioned in the directive are either the direct product of an OIG report or are mentioned to be following from the findings of an OIG report. This excludes instances where Congress cites a fact or statistic from an OIG report to justify the directive to implement recommendations otherwise not produced by an OIG. I include instances where the language of the directive includes strict language such as ‘order’ and ‘direct’ as well as ‘softer’ language such as ‘encourages’ and ‘supports’ with respect to Congress’s order to the agency. I make the assumption that even these directives with softer language are reflective of Congress’s oversight preferences and that agencies face similar pressures to be responsive to these directives. Below is an example of a directive to the SBA to implement OIG recommendations with regards to SBA’s lender oversight process—note that it does not contain an explicit ‘directive’ or ‘order’ or even a reporting requirement but still clearly communicates Congress’s preferences for SBA’s operations.

Oversight.—The Committee is concerned about the quality of lender oversight activities at SBA, particularly considering the magnitude of SBA’s loan port-

folio, and notes that SBA's Office of Inspector General continues to identify weaknesses in SBA's lender oversight process. The Committee agrees with SBA's Inspector General recommendations and supports efforts to strengthen the Office of Credit Monitoring's ability to conduct strong oversight of SBA loan portfolios and the lenders that participate in order to reinforce general program soundness and manage overall risk. (Financial Services and General Government Appropriations Bill House Appropriations Committee Report, June 28th, 2019)

The other main category is directives that direct an OIG to conduct an audit or an investigation, focus their existing investigations on a specific area, or otherwise gather information about the operations of an agency. I examined each directive to an OIG and determined whether Congress was directing the agency to gather information about the OIG's respective agency, thus excluding instances where Congress directed OIGs to gather information about their own office. Like with the previous category, I include directives with both 'strict' and 'soft' language with respect to Congress's directive to the OIG. Below is an example of a directive to an OIG, specifically the Department of Justice OIG, to focus on the management of finances of a specific sub-agency in the Department of Justice with the new money appropriated to it by Congress. The directive does not include strict language nor a reporting requirement, but the directive is still reflective of the House's desire to control the oversight agenda of the DOJ OIG, indicating an overall interest in DOJ oversight by the House.

Grants management.—The Committee's recommendation also includes an increase of \$2,000,000 for enhanced auditing and oversight of the Department's grant programs. In the execution of these funds, the Committee urges OIG to include a focus on financial management issues at the Office of Justice Programs (OJP). The Committee is particularly interested in assessing OJP's ability to track the disbursement of its appropriations by activity. (Commerce, Justice, Science and Related Agencies Appropriations Bill House Appropriations Committee Report, June 12th, 2009)

Finally, I determined whether each directive includes a reporting requirement or not. Specifically, I look for directives that order either the agency or the OIG to provide a report to either chamber of Congress and/or either appropriations committee with respect to the progress of the agency in implementing the OIG recommendations or with respect to the results of the audit/investigation conducted by the OIG. Most of these reporting requirements include a deadline, mandating that the report be provided to Congress within x days of the passage of the appropriations bill, but I do not code for it in this analysis. Table 11 includes the mean annual directives of each category for each agency in the empirical analysis.

Table 11: Mean Annual Directives by Agency

Agency	Agency Implement	Agency Report	OIG Audit	OIG Report
CNCS	0.08	0.08	0.19	0.15
DHS	3.30	2.67	2.85	2.03
DOC	2.00	1.20	2.00	0.53
DOE	0.78	0.50	0.16	0.16
DOI	0.47	0.32	0.26	0.12
DOJ	1.37	0.90	1.53	0.80
DOL	0.78	0.26	0.09	0.00
DOT	2.21	1.21	2.36	2.24
ED	0.15	0.12	0.04	0.04
EPA	0.50	0.42	0.33	0.17
FCC	0.06	0.03	0.03	0.00
FDIC	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
GSA	0.19	0.16	0.00	0.00
HHS	0.64	0.36	0.64	0.36
HUD	1.24	0.82	0.88	0.82
NASA	0.84	0.65	0.29	0.13
NRC	0.03	0.03	0.06	0.00
NSF	0.39	0.36	0.21	0.18
OPM	0.22	0.22	0.41	0.25
SBA	0.66	0.34	0.34	0.34
SEC	0.09	0.00	0.06	0.06
SSA	0.31	0.23	0.04	0.00
STATE	0.80	0.60	1.12	0.24
TREAS	3.12	1.38	2.34	1.16
USAID	0.12	0.09	0.56	0.22
USDA	1.53	1.26	0.94	0.06
VA	0.10	0.10	0.70	0.20

D Agencies in each empirical analysis

The availability of data for each agency in each empirical analysis varied, hence the varied sample across the various empirical analyses. The most common causes were the OMB budget data not including every agency's OIG as a separate budget account, some agencies not having politicization or ideology data, and some agencies not having any OIG witness observations across the entire empirical analysis in Table 7. Table 12 lists each agency present in at least one of the empirical analyses and the analyses that they appear in.

Table 12: Agencies within each empirical analysis

Agency	OIG Budgets (Table 3)	Cabinet OIG Budgets (Table 4)	OIG Directives (Tables 5 & 6)	OIG Witnesses (Table 7)
CNCS			✓	
DHS	✓	✓	✓	✓
DOC	✓	✓	✓	✓
DOD	✓	✓		
DOE	✓	✓	✓	✓
DOI	✓	✓	✓	✓
DOJ	✓	✓	✓	✓
DOL	✓	✓	✓	✓
DOT	✓	✓	✓	✓
ED	✓	✓	✓	✓
EPA	✓		✓	✓
FCC			✓	
FDIC			✓	✓
GSA	✓		✓	✓
HHS	✓	✓	✓	✓
HUD	✓	✓	✓	✓
NASA	✓		✓	✓
NRC	✓		✓	
NSF	✓		✓	✓
OPM	✓		✓	✓
SBA	✓		✓	✓
SEC			✓	✓
SSA	✓		✓	✓
STATE	✓	✓	✓	✓
TREAS	✓	✓	✓	✓
USAID			✓	✓
USDA	✓	✓	✓	✓
VA	✓	✓	✓	✓

E OIG Budget Analysis Alternative Specifications

- Table 13—Controlling for agency discretionary budget authority
- Table 14—Controlling for agency discretionary budget authority among cabinet agencies
- Table 15—Year Clustered SEs
- Table 16—Cabinet agencies, Year Clustered SEs
- Table 17—Controlling for agency discretionary budget authority, Year Clustered SEs
- Table 18—Controlling for agency discretionary budget authority among cabinet agencies, Year Clustered SEs

Table 13: Estimating the Effects of Congressional & Agency Characteristics on OIG Budget Authority (2006-2023)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Rep. House	-0.036 (0.021)				-0.033 (0.022)	-0.033 (0.022)
Rep. Senate	0.008 (0.011)				0.024 (0.015)	0.024 (0.015)
# Out-Partisan Chambers		-0.009 (0.012)			-0.009 (0.015)	-0.011 (0.021)
Agency Politicization			-3.047 (3.862)		-3.022 (3.870)	-3.172 (3.988)
House-Agency Ideological Alignment				0.019 (0.011)	0.014 (0.010)	0.014 (0.010)
Senate-Agency Ideological Alignment				0.010 (0.008)	0.012 (0.009)	0.013 (0.009)
# Out-Partisan Chambers x Agency Politicization						0.143 (0.676)
log(Agency Discretionary Budget+1)	0.156* (0.061)	0.163* (0.061)	0.160* (0.060)	0.162* (0.060)	0.148* (0.060)	0.148* (0.061)
GAO High Risk List	0.016 (0.020)	0.017 (0.021)	0.014 (0.019)	0.016 (0.021)	0.017 (0.020)	0.017 (0.020)
Observations	385	385	385	385	385	385
R ²	0.978	0.977	0.978	0.978	0.978	0.978
R ² Within	0.131	0.124	0.136	0.136	0.154	0.154
Agency Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
President Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note:

⁺p<0.1; *p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001
Standard errors are clustered by agency.

Table 14: Estimating the Effects of Congressional & Agency Characteristics on OIG Budget Authority (2006-2023) (excluding non-cabinet agencies)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Rep. House	-0.029 (0.024)				-0.025 (0.027)	-0.026 (0.026)
Rep. Senate	0.013 (0.012)				0.019 (0.016)	0.022 (0.016)
# Out-Partisan Chambers		0.004 (0.013)			0.003 (0.019)	-0.012 (0.018)
Agency Politicization			-3.468 (5.032)		-3.568 (5.330)	-4.849 (5.388)
House-Agency Ideological Alignment				0.013 (0.012)	0.009 (0.011)	0.009 (0.011)
Senate-Agency Ideological Alignment				0.000 (0.006)	0.004 (0.005)	0.004 (0.006)
# Out-Partisan Chambers x Agency Politicization						0.929* (0.360)
log(Agency Discretionary Budget+1)	0.310** (0.095)	0.325** (0.094)	0.312** (0.086)	0.319** (0.091)	0.299** (0.092)	0.299** (0.093)
GAO High Risk List	-0.005 (0.024)	-0.006 (0.025)	-0.003 (0.023)	-0.005 (0.025)	-0.003 (0.024)	-0.002 (0.024)
Observations	236	236	236	236	236	236
R ²	0.937	0.937	0.938	0.937	0.939	0.939
R ² Within	0.224	0.220	0.234	0.224	0.243	0.250
Agency Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
President Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note:

⁺p<0.1; *p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001
Standard errors are clustered by agency.

Table 15: Estimating the Effects of Congressional & Agency Characteristics on OIG Budget Authority (2006-2023)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Rep. House	-0.036 (0.028)				-0.035 (0.025)	-0.035 (0.025)
Rep. Senate	0.002 (0.021)				0.021 (0.024)	0.021 (0.024)
# Out-Partisan Chambers		-0.015 (0.017)			-0.016 (0.012)	-0.019 (0.018)
Agency Politicization			-2.456 (1.898)		-2.364 (1.794)	-2.575 (1.962)
House-Agency Ideological Alignment				0.018 (0.013)	0.013 (0.011)	0.013 (0.011)
Senate-Agency Ideological Alignment				0.012 (0.011)	0.014 (0.011)	0.014 (0.011)
# Out-Partisan Chambers x Agency Politicization						0.196 (0.808)
log(Agency Budget+1)	0.086*** (0.010)	0.091*** (0.011)	0.088*** (0.013)	0.090*** (0.010)	0.081*** (0.013)	0.081*** (0.014)
GAO High Risk List	0.017 (0.018)	0.020 (0.019)	0.016 (0.018)	0.018 (0.018)	0.020 (0.018)	0.020 (0.018)
Observations	381	381	381	381	381	381
R ²	0.977	0.977	0.977	0.977	0.978	0.978
R ² Within	0.112	0.107	0.112	0.117	0.133	0.133
Agency Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
President Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note:

⁺p<0.1; *p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001
Standard errors are clustered by year.

Table 16: Estimating the Effects of Congressional & Agency Characteristics on OIG Budget Authority (2006-2023) (excluding non-cabinet agencies)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Rep. House	-0.043+				-0.047+	-0.048+
	(0.024)				(0.024)	(0.023)
Rep. Senate	-0.006				0.009	0.012
	(0.021)				(0.023)	(0.023)
# Out-Partisan Chambers		-0.012			-0.014	-0.032+
		(0.017)			(0.010)	(0.016)
Agency Politicization			-4.016		-3.902	-5.596*
			(2.481)		(2.343)	(2.598)
House-Agency Ideological Alignment				0.014	0.009	0.009
				(0.011)	(0.011)	(0.011)
Senate-Agency Ideological Alignment				0.003	0.004	0.005
				(0.009)	(0.009)	(0.009)
# Out-Partisan Chambers x Agency Politicization						1.127
						(0.790)
log(Agency Budget+1)	0.111**	0.125**	0.119**	0.123**	0.100**	0.103*
	(0.034)	(0.035)	(0.035)	(0.036)	(0.033)	(0.036)
GAO High Risk List	0.012	0.014	0.013	0.012	0.016	0.016
	(0.014)	(0.014)	(0.014)	(0.015)	(0.013)	(0.014)
Observations	234	234	234	234	234	234
R ²	0.927	0.926	0.928	0.926	0.929	0.930
R ² Within	0.099	0.088	0.105	0.092	0.124	0.134
Agency Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
President Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note:

⁺p<0.1; *p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001
Standard errors are clustered by year.

Table 17: Estimating the Effects of Congressional & Agency Characteristics on OIG Budget Authority (2006-2023)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Rep. House	-0.036+				-0.033+	-0.033+
	(0.020)				(0.018)	(0.018)
Rep. Senate	0.008				0.024	0.024
	(0.018)				(0.020)	(0.020)
# Out-Partisan Chambers		-0.009			-0.009	-0.011
		(0.014)			(0.009)	(0.014)
Agency Politicization			-3.047+		-3.022*	-3.172+
			(1.558)		(1.429)	(1.541)
House-Agency Ideological Alignment				0.019	0.014	0.014
				(0.012)	(0.010)	(0.010)
Senate-Agency Ideological Alignment				0.010	0.012	0.013
				(0.010)	(0.010)	(0.010)
# Out-Partisan Chambers x Agency Politicization						0.143
						(0.619)
log(Agency Discretionary Budget+1)	0.156***	0.163***	0.160***	0.162***	0.148***	0.148***
	(0.017)	(0.019)	(0.019)	(0.018)	(0.019)	(0.019)
GAO High Risk List	0.016	0.017	0.014	0.016	0.017	0.017
	(0.014)	(0.014)	(0.014)	(0.014)	(0.014)	(0.014)
Observations	385	385	385	385	385	385
R ²	0.978	0.978	0.978	0.978	0.978	0.978
R ² Within	0.131	0.129	0.136	0.136	0.154	0.154
Agency Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
President Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note:

⁺p<0.1; *p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001
Standard errors are clustered by year.

Table 18: Estimating the Effects of Congressional & Agency Characteristics on OIG Budget Authority (2006-2023) (excluding non-cabinet agencies)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Rep. House	-0.029* (0.013)				-0.025 (0.015)	-0.026 (0.015)
Rep. Senate	0.013 (0.017)				0.019 (0.017)	0.022 (0.017)
# Out-Partisan Chambers		0.004 (0.008)			0.003 (0.007)	-0.012 (0.010)
Agency Politicization			-3.468+ (1.903)		-3.568+ (1.947)	-4.849* (2.054)
House-Agency Ideological Alignment				0.013 (0.008)	0.009 (0.009)	0.009 (0.008)
Senate-Agency Ideological Alignment				0.000 (0.007)	0.004 (0.007)	0.004 (0.007)
# Out-Partisan Chambers x Agency Politicization						0.929+ (0.489)
log(Agency Discretionary Budget+1)	0.310*** (0.034)	0.325*** (0.033)	0.312*** (0.027)	0.319*** (0.031)	0.299*** (0.033)	0.299*** (0.032)
GAO High Risk List	-0.005 (0.009)	-0.006 (0.008)	-0.003 (0.009)	-0.005 (0.009)	-0.003 (0.009)	-0.002 (0.010)
Observations	236	236	236	236	236	236
R ²	0.937	0.937	0.938	0.937	0.939	0.939
R ² Within	0.224	0.220	0.234	0.224	0.243	0.250
Agency Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
President Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note:

⁺p<0.1; *p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001
Standard errors are clustered by year.

F Directives Analysis Alternative Specifications

- Table 19—Directives to agencies without conditioning on reporting requirements
- Table 20—Directives to OIGs without conditioning on reporting requirements
- Table 21—Directives to agencies with reporting requirement, Year Clustered SEs
- Table 22—Directives to OIGs with reporting requirement, Year Clustered SEs
- Table 23—Directives to agencies without conditioning on reporting requirements, Year Clustered SEs
- Table 24—Directives to OIGs without conditioning on reporting requirements, Year Clustered SEs

Table 19: Effects of Congressional and Agency Characteristics on directives to implement OIG recommendations (2005-2024)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Presidential Out-Party	-0.003 (0.104)				0.067 (0.090)	0.127 (0.126)
Agency Politicization		6.404 (5.429)			5.870 (5.721)	8.270 (5.973)
Chamber-Agency Ideological Alignment			0.038 (0.057)		0.010 (0.069)	0.010 (0.069)
Republican				-0.129 (0.129)	-0.102 (0.146)	-0.104 (0.147)
Presidential Out-Party x Agency Politicization						-3.926 (3.878)
Senate					0.189 (0.183)	0.189 (0.183)
Divided Chambers					-0.052 (0.109)	-0.059 (0.109)
$\log(\text{Audit Reports} + 1) \ t - 1$	-0.255 (0.199)	-0.254 (0.196)	-0.256 (0.196)	-0.261 (0.197)	-0.248 (0.199)	-0.254 (0.200)
GAO High Risk List	0.212 (0.223)	0.213 (0.223)	0.213 (0.221)	0.206 (0.223)	0.196 (0.222)	0.195 (0.223)
Observations	794	794	794	794	794	794
R ²	0.361	0.361	0.361	0.362	0.366	0.366
R ² Within	0.009	0.010	0.009	0.011	0.017	0.018
Agency Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
President Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note:

⁺p<0.1; *p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001
Standard errors are clustered by agency.

Table 20: Effects of Congressional and Agency Characteristics on directives to OIG to conduct audit/investigation (2005-2024)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Presidential Out-Party	0.034 (0.094)				0.107 (0.088)	0.149 (0.112)
Agency Politicization		3.272 (3.192)			2.467 (3.312)	4.179 (4.600)
Chamber-Agency Ideological Alignment			-0.032 (0.041)		-0.031 (0.056)	-0.030 (0.056)
Republican				0.013 (0.087)	0.007 (0.128)	0.006 (0.128)
Presidential Out-Party x Agency Politicization						-2.801 (4.023)
Senate					0.178 (0.130)	0.178 (0.130)
Divided Chambers					-0.069 (0.072)	-0.075 (0.072)
$\log(\text{Audit Reports} + 1) \ t - 1$	-0.034 (0.133)	-0.046 (0.113)	-0.044 (0.113)	-0.045 (0.114)	-0.020 (0.140)	-0.024 (0.141)
GAO High Risk List	0.569*** (0.132)	0.574*** (0.128)	0.571*** (0.128)	0.573*** (0.127)	0.555*** (0.131)	0.554*** (0.130)
Observations	794	794	794	794	794	794
R ²	0.469	0.469	0.469	0.468	0.473	0.474
R ² Within	0.070	0.070	0.070	0.070	0.078	0.079
Agency Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
President Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note:

⁺p<0.1; *p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001
Standard errors are clustered by agency.

Table 21: Effects of Congressional and Agency Characteristics on directives to agency to implement OIG recommendations with reporting requirement (2005-2024)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Presidential Out-Party	0.079 (0.065)				0.066 (0.060)	0.101 (0.095)
Agency Politicization		4.339 (3.037)			3.154 (3.046)	4.548 (3.563)
Chamber-Agency Ideological Alignment			0.064 (0.038)		0.062 (0.054)	0.063 (0.055)
Republican				-0.037 (0.068)	0.004 (0.099)	0.003 (0.099)
Presidential Out-Party x Agency Politicization						-2.280 (3.350)
Senate					-0.001 (0.087)	-0.001 (0.087)
Divided Chambers					0.023 (0.100)	0.019 (0.103)
$\log(\text{Audit Reports} + 1) \ t - 1$	-0.151 (0.114)	-0.179 (0.109)	-0.181 (0.111)	-0.181 (0.110)	-0.155 (0.118)	-0.159 (0.118)
GAO High Risk List	0.041 (0.099)	0.051 (0.100)	0.053 (0.100)	0.048 (0.101)	0.047 (0.100)	0.046 (0.100)
Observations	794	794	794	794	794	794
R ²	0.301	0.301	0.302	0.301	0.304	0.304
R ² Within	0.005	0.005	0.006	0.004	0.008	0.009
Agency Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
President Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note: ⁺p<0.1; *p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001
Standard errors are clustered by year.

Table 22: Effects of Congressional and Agency Characteristics on directives to OIG to conduct audit/investigation with reporting requirement (2005-2024)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Presidential Out-Party	0.044 (0.062)				0.032 (0.058)	0.070 (0.081)
Agency Politicization		6.312+ (3.348)			5.611 (3.243)	7.098+ (3.561)
Chamber-Agency Ideological Alignment			-0.026 (0.037)		-0.049 (0.044)	-0.049 (0.044)
Republican				-0.052 (0.060)	-0.081 (0.071)	-0.082 (0.071)
Presidential Out-Party x Agency Politicization						-2.432 (3.029)
Senate					0.001 (0.045)	0.001 (0.045)
Divided Chambers					0.025 (0.064)	0.020 (0.064)
$\log(\text{Audit Reports} + 1) \ t - 1$	-0.032 (0.085)	-0.048 (0.082)	-0.047 (0.082)	-0.051 (0.085)	-0.036 (0.083)	-0.040 (0.081)
GAO High Risk List	0.261*** (0.050)	0.267*** (0.051)	0.265*** (0.050)	0.263*** (0.048)	0.258*** (0.051)	0.257*** (0.051)
Observations	794	794	794	794	794	794
R ²	0.432	0.434	0.432	0.433	0.436	0.436
R ² Within	0.029	0.031	0.029	0.029	0.035	0.036
Agency Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
President Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note:

⁺p<0.1; *p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001
Standard errors are clustered by year.

Table 23: Effects of Congressional and Agency Characteristics on directives to implement OIG recommendations (2005-2024)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Presidential Out-Party	-0.003 (0.095)				0.067 (0.071)	0.127 (0.123)
Agency Politicization		6.404+ (3.521)			5.870 (3.396)	8.270+ (4.230)
Chamber-Agency Ideological Alignment			0.038 (0.059)		0.010 (0.092)	0.010 (0.091)
Republican				-0.129 (0.100)	-0.102 (0.138)	-0.104 (0.137)
Presidential Out-Party x Agency Politicization						-3.926 (4.721)
Senate					0.189+ (0.102)	0.189+ (0.102)
Divided Chambers					-0.052 (0.128)	-0.059 (0.131)
$\log(\text{Audit Reports} + 1) \ t - 1$	-0.255 (0.149)	-0.254 (0.150)	-0.256 (0.152)	-0.261 (0.153)	-0.248 (0.153)	-0.254 (0.154)
GAO High Risk List	0.212 (0.134)	0.213 (0.136)	0.213 (0.137)	0.206 (0.138)	0.196 (0.133)	0.195 (0.133)
Observations	794	794	794	794	794	794
R ²	0.361	0.361	0.361	0.362	0.366	0.366
R ² Within	0.009	0.010	0.009	0.011	0.017	0.018
Agency Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
President Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note:

⁺p<0.1; *p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001
Standard errors are clustered by year.

Table 24: Effects of Congressional and Agency Characteristics on directives to OIG to conduct audit/investigation (2005-2024)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Presidential Out-Party	0.034 (0.080)				0.107 (0.066)	0.149+ (0.084)
Agency Politicization		3.272 (3.815)			2.467 (3.566)	4.179 (4.215)
Chamber-Agency Ideological Alignment			-0.032 (0.041)		-0.031 (0.049)	-0.030 (0.049)
Republican				0.013 (0.075)	0.007 (0.078)	0.006 (0.077)
Presidential Out-Party x Agency Politicization						-2.801 (2.954)
Senate					0.178* (0.077)	0.178* (0.076)
Divided Chambers					-0.069 (0.079)	-0.075 (0.079)
log(Audit Reports +1) $t - 1$	-0.034 (0.089)	-0.046 (0.086)	-0.044 (0.086)	-0.045 (0.086)	-0.020 (0.090)	-0.024 (0.089)
GAO High Risk List	0.569*** (0.087)	0.574*** (0.085)	0.571*** (0.085)	0.573*** (0.085)	0.555*** (0.086)	0.554*** (0.086)
Observations	794	794	794	794	794	794
R ²	0.469	0.469	0.469	0.468	0.473	0.474
R ² Within	0.070	0.070	0.070	0.070	0.078	0.079
Agency Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
President Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note:

⁺p<0.1; *p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001
Standard errors are clustered by year.

G **OIG Witness Descriptive Tables**

The following tables present descriptive statistics from data collected from the Statements of Activities Reports from the House Committee on Oversight and Government Reform and the Senate Committee on Homeland Security and Governmental Affairs from 2005 to 2022. Not all agencies listed in Table 26 are in the empirical analyses due to a lack of data availability for politicization, agency ideology, or otherwise. Each Special Inspector General witness was aggregated with their respective agency (SIGTARP and TIGTA with Treasury, SIGAR and SIGIR with State).

Table 25: Number of witness invitations for each year-committee pair (2005-2022)

Year	House Oversight Committee		Senate Oversight Committee	
	# OIG Staff	# IGs	# OIG Staff	# IGs
2005	21	14	5	3
2006	18	12	12	9
2007	18	13	7	6
2008	7	3	6	4
2009	17	16	11	7
2010	13	11	17	11
2011	23	13	16	11
2012	25	14	9	7
2013	33	17	11	6
2014	25	15	14	13
2015	30	19	13	11
2016	18	9	6	6
2017	23	16	5	4
2018	11	8	4	2
2019	13	9	2	1
2020	4	2	1	1
2021	9	7	3	2
2022	7	4	4	4
Total	315	202	146	108

Table 26: Number of House and Senate Oversight Committee witness invitations for each
OIG (2005-2022)

Agency	# OIG Staff	# IGs
Amtrak	2	2
Appalachian Regional Commission	1	1
Army	1	1
Federal Reserve	1	1
Commodity Futures Trading Commission	1	1
Department of Homeland Security	65	45
Department of Commerce	15	11
Department of Defense	45	19
Department of Energy	9	7
Department of the Interior	11	5
Department of Justice	37	35
Department of Labor	4	3
Department of Transportation	6	4
Department of Education	8	6
Environmental Protection Agency	13	5
Export-Import Bank	3	2
Federal Deposit Insurance Corporation	2	2
Government Publishing Office	2	2
General Services Administration	14	11
Department of Health and Human Services	22	4
Department of Housing and Urban Development	3	3
Intelligence Community	3	2
National Archives and Records Administration	3	3
National Aeronautics and Space Administration	1	1
National Credit Union Administration	1	1
National Science Foundation	4	4
Office of Personnel Management	12	9
Peace Corps	6	6
Railroad Retirement Board	1	1
Small Business Administration	9	8
Securities and Exchange Commission	2	2
Special Inspector General for Afghanistan Reconstruction	17	15
Special Inspector General for Iraq Reconstruction	16	15
Special Inspector General for the Troubled Asset Relief Program	9	9
Social Security Administration	8	7
Department of State	17	7
Treasury Inspector General for Tax Administration	22	11
Department of Treasury	6	5
Tennessee Valley Authority	1	1
United States Agency for International Development	10	6
Department of Agriculture	9	8
United States Election Assistance Commission	1	0
United States Postal Service	21	13
Department of Veterans Affairs	14	3
Washington Metropolitan Area Transit Authority	3	3
Total	461	310

H **OIG Witness Analysis Alternative Specifications**

- Table 27—Alternative specification with number of Inspectors General witnesses as the outcome variable (excluding non-IG staff in OIG offices)
- Table 28—Year Clustered SEs
- Table 29—Alternative specification with number of Inspectors General witnesses as the outcome variable, including Year Clustered SEs
- Table 30—Hearing-level analysis

Table 27: IG Witness Invitation Patterns for House and Senate Oversight Committee Hearings (2005-2022)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Presidential Out-Party	-0.048 (0.048)				-0.050 (0.049)	-0.054 (0.058)
Politicization		0.363 (2.309)			0.765 (2.429)	0.637 (2.174)
Chamber-Agency Ideological Alignment			0.022 (0.048)		0.057 (0.062)	0.057 (0.061)
Republican				0.099 (0.070)	0.141 (0.105)	0.142 (0.105)
Presidential Out-Party x Politicization						0.237 (2.947)
Senate	-0.187* (0.074)	-0.168* (0.071)	-0.170* (0.073)	-0.160* (0.072)	-0.179* (0.074)	-0.179* (0.074)
Committee Staff	0.001 (0.002)	0.001 (0.002)	0.001 (0.002)	0.001 (0.002)	0.001 (0.002)	0.001 (0.002)
Total Hearings Held	0.000 (0.001)	0.001 (0.001)	0.001 (0.001)	0.001 (0.001)	0.000 (0.001)	0.000 (0.001)
GAO High Risk List	-0.025 (0.079)	-0.031 (0.078)	-0.029 (0.076)	-0.025 (0.078)	-0.014 (0.077)	-0.014 (0.077)
log(Audit Reports+1) $t - 1$	-0.089 (0.112)	-0.077 (0.110)	-0.076 (0.109)	-0.075 (0.108)	-0.086 (0.113)	-0.085 (0.113)
Observations	794	794	794	794	794	794
R ²	0.260	0.259	0.260	0.263	0.267	0.267
R ² Within	0.026	0.025	0.026	0.030	0.036	0.036
Agency Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
President Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note:

⁺p<0.1; *p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001
Standard errors are clustered by agency.

Table 28: OIG Witness Invitation Patterns for House and Senate Oversight Committee Hearings (2005-2022)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Presidential Out-Party	-0.013 (0.095)				-0.011 (0.083)	-0.029 (0.077)
Politicization		0.280 (3.600)			0.268 (3.455)	-0.357 (3.039)
Chamber-Agency Ideological Alignment			-0.006 (0.036)		0.048 (0.037)	0.048 (0.037)
Republican				0.184* (0.078)	0.220* (0.086)	0.221* (0.086)
Presidential Out-Party x Politicization						1.154 (2.350)
Senate	-0.245+ (0.127)	-0.240+ (0.135)	-0.240+ (0.135)	-0.224+ (0.120)	-0.228+ (0.117)	-0.228+ (0.117)
Committee Staff	0.001 (0.003)	0.001 (0.002)	0.001 (0.002)	0.001 (0.002)	0.001 (0.002)	0.001 (0.002)
Total Hearings Held	0.002 (0.002)	0.002 (0.002)	0.002 (0.002)	0.002 (0.002)	0.002 (0.002)	0.002 (0.002)
GAO High Risk List	-0.026 (0.092)	-0.027 (0.091)	-0.028 (0.090)	-0.018 (0.090)	-0.012 (0.093)	-0.011 (0.093)
$\log(\text{Audit Reports}+1) \ t - 1$	-0.059 (0.080)	-0.056 (0.090)	-0.056 (0.088)	-0.053 (0.081)	-0.054 (0.079)	-0.052 (0.079)
Observations	794	794	794	794	794	794
R ²	0.272	0.272	0.272	0.280	0.281	0.281
R ² Within	0.037	0.037	0.037	0.047	0.049	0.049
Agency Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
President Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note:

⁺p<0.1; *p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001
Standard errors are clustered by year.

Table 29: IG Witness Invitation Patterns for House and Senate Oversight Committee Hearings (2005-2022)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Presidential Out-Party	-0.048 (0.059)				-0.050 (0.055)	-0.054 (0.056)
Politicization		0.363 (2.872)			0.765 (2.746)	0.637 (2.801)
Chamber-Agency Ideological Alignment			0.022 (0.030)		0.057+ (0.033)	0.057+ (0.033)
Republican				0.099+ (0.054)	0.141* (0.061)	0.142* (0.062)
Presidential Out-Party x Politicization						0.237 (2.375)
Senate	-0.187+ (0.093)	-0.168+ (0.093)	-0.170+ (0.095)	-0.160+ (0.085)	-0.179+ (0.087)	-0.179+ (0.087)
Committee Staff	0.001 (0.002)	0.001 (0.002)	0.001 (0.002)	0.001 (0.002)	0.001 (0.002)	0.001 (0.002)
Total Hearings Held	0.000 (0.001)	0.001 (0.001)	0.001 (0.001)	0.001 (0.001)	0.000 (0.001)	0.000 (0.001)
GAO High Risk List	-0.025 (0.066)	-0.031 (0.066)	-0.029 (0.066)	-0.025 (0.065)	-0.014 (0.066)	-0.014 (0.066)
$\log(\text{Audit Reports}+1) \ t - 1$	-0.089 (0.070)	-0.077 (0.072)	-0.076 (0.071)	-0.075 (0.068)	-0.086 (0.073)	-0.085 (0.073)
Observations	794	794	794	794	794	794
R ²	0.260	0.259	0.260	0.263	0.267	0.267
R ² Within	0.026	0.025	0.026	0.030	0.036	0.036
Agency Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
President Fixed Effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note:

⁺p<0.1; *p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001
Standard errors are clustered by year.

Table 30: OIG Witness Invitation patterns for House and Senate Oversight Committee Hearings (2005-2018)

	(Has OIG Witness)	(# of OIG Witnesses)
Presidential Out-Party	0.027* (0.010)	0.015 (0.013)
Republican	0.020+ (0.010)	0.034+ (0.016)
Senate	-0.051* (0.015)	-0.098** (0.018)
Committee Staff	0.001+ (0.000)	0.001** (0.000)
Lawmaking Hearing	-0.078* (0.030)	-0.102 (0.055)
Observations	1942	1942
R ²	0.050	0.037
R ² Within	0.013	0.011
CAP Topic Fixed Effects	✓	✓
President Fixed Effects	✓	✓

Note: ⁺p<0.1; *p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001
Standard errors are clustered by Congress.